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Passion Pursuits: A Guide to Independent Student Learning

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Passion Pursuits: A Guide to Independent Student Learning

Description

Passion Pursuits is designed as differentiated enrichment for gifted learners. Integrated across several content areas, Passion Pursuits offer opportunities for reading, research, writing, and the creation of a variety of products. When used in a pullout setting where learners come together for a period of time each day or each week, some of the activities and lessons may be done independently outside of school. When used in a home school setting, field experiences may dominate the research section of the unit and greater lengths of time may be allocated to each project, allowing for expansion and complexity in both concepts and product. In a general classroom setting, Passion Pursuits may be used as center-type enrichment, as a designated class time for all students once or twice a week, or as a month long research skill curriculum focus.

Keywords

Curriculum, Independent study, Multidisciplinary, Gifted education

Disciplines

Curriculum and Instruction | Education | Educational Methods | Elementary Education | Gifted Education

Publisher

University of Denver

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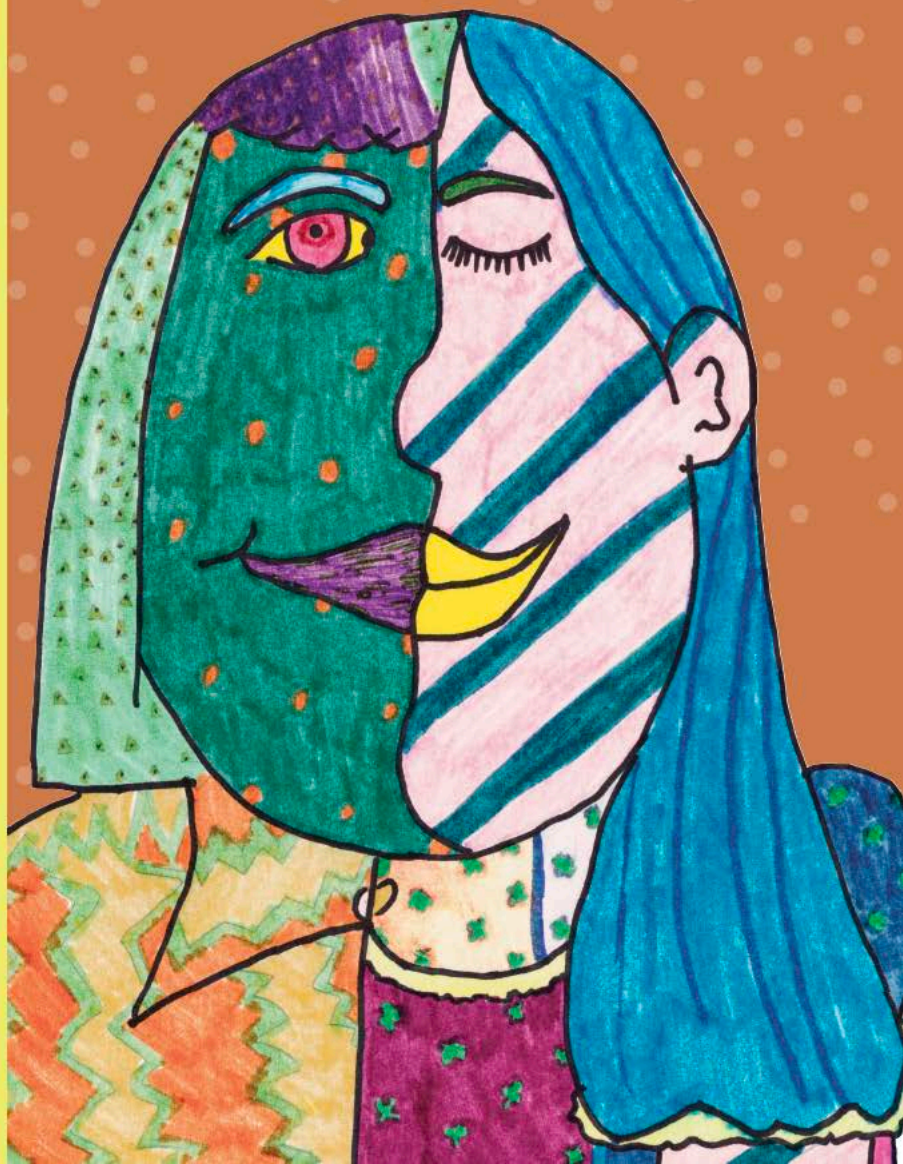
Passion Pursuits

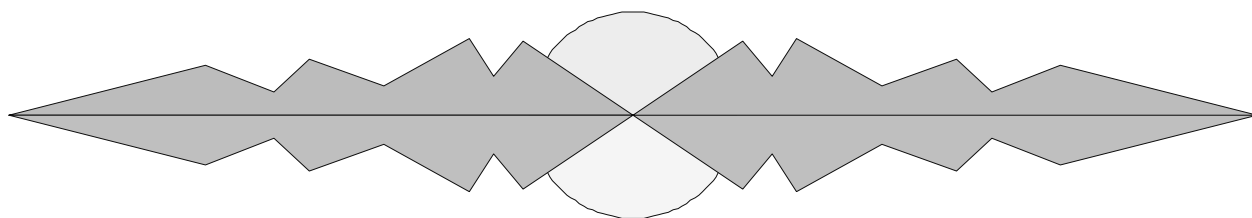
A COMPILATION OF INDEPENDENT UNITS

Institute for the
Development of
Gifted Education

Ricks Center for
Gifted Children

UNIVERSITY OF
DENVER





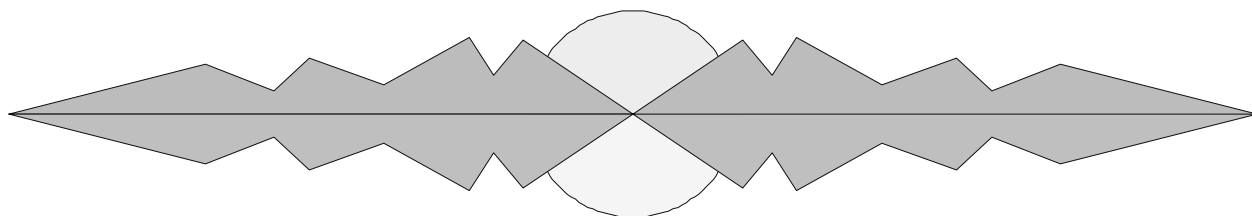
PASSION PURSUITS

A GUIDE TO INDEPENDENT STUDENT LEARNING

INSTITUTE FOR THE DEVELOPMENT OF GIFTED EDUCATION

RICKS CENTER FOR GIFTED CHILDREN

UNIVERSITY OF DENVER



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First Edition
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Printed in the United States of America
ISBN 0-9676158-7-9

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- Africa
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- Australia
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- Early Childhood Thematic Units
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Other books are in the planning phase. Additional information is available about Ricks Center materials and the Ricks Center for Gifted Children at the University of Denver, serving gifted learners ages three through fourteen.

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

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Passion Pursuits Piloted by Ricks Center Faculty

Funded by

The Lynde and Harry Bradley Foundation

through the

*Institute for the Development of Gifted Education
at the University of Denver*

Any omission of acknowledgement is unintentional.

INTRODUCTION

Gifted children are intense, sensitive, and have the ability to see connections in seemingly unrelated areas. Above all, they are curious. When describing a gifted child, people often begin by sharing a particular interest of the child. But far beyond the typical interest, instead what is described is a passion. Gifted children tend to develop intense interests around specific ideas, areas, or topics. Beyond a hobby or typical academic pursuit, these passions are often the driving force in the gifted child's life. Parents describe children who request unusual items, such as a VandeGraaff generator or a dwarf orange tree for birthday gifts. Teachers tell of students who are consumed by the need to know everything regarding the Titanic or the artwork of Vincent Van Gogh. These passionate interests may last weeks or years.

Passion Pursuits is an independent study plan based on an individual learner's personal interests. In addition to exploring a passion more completely, independent units provide an opportunity for learners to engage in a range of skills involved in independent research and the creation of various products.

The following guide helps teachers and learners alike as they begin the process of using Passion Pursuits within their curriculum. Passion Pursuits work well in a variety of settings. Independent units can be done in the general classroom by all learners, acting as either an extension of the regular curriculum or as a replacement. Passion Pursuits also work well in pull-out programs or cluster groupings where small groups of learners from various classrooms come together to work on the common goal of independent research while investigating their own personal interests. Passion Pursuits provides a curricular structure to home schooling families and may also serve as a general after school enrichment program.

The Passion Pursuit units included in this book invite learners to become active and enthusiastic participants in their own learning. Each topic contains several different tasks or projects designed to help a beginning researcher learn more about an area of interest. Additionally, areas such as language arts, investigation, art, science, and problem solving are carefully woven into each set of tasks to provide a balanced curricular experience. Topics are varied and represent a wide range of interests, abilities, and levels. Passion Pursuits may be used as is, by simply providing learners with the enclosed list from which to select a topic, or may be used as a starting point for creating more personalized experiences for your learners.

Organizing and Customizing Passion Pursuits for Your Setting:

Setting: Passion Pursuits is designed as differentiated enrichment for gifted learners. Integrated across several content areas, Passion Pursuits offer opportunities for reading, research, writing, and the creation of a variety of products. When used in a pullout setting where learners come together for a period of time each day or each week, some of the activities and lessons may be done independently outside of school. When used in a home school setting, field experiences may dominate the research section of the unit and greater lengths of time may be allocated to each project, allowing for expansion and complexity in both concepts and product. In a general classroom setting, Passion Pursuits may be used as center-type enrichment, as a designated class time for all students once or twice a week, or as a month long research skill curriculum focus.

Topic Selection: Topic selection may be done in several ways. If you will be using the enclosed suggestions for passions, pass the topic list around for learners to preview or post in a general classroom location. Invite learners to ask questions about the topics and provide additional information as needed. Utilize the student guide to help learners create their own focus questions. This will enable learners to refine their interests, allowing them to narrow their choices to four or five topics. Use a conference to further define what learners are actually hoping to discover. Many gifted students have multiple interests, some of which may be satisfied with a brief discussion or

through limited research. These are topics that should be set aside during this process. Topics that should be focused on are those that have either been a longstanding interest (the unquenchable passion) or those in which students are truly interested in a larger concept or structure of the discipline. For example, a student may express an interest in a Passion Pursuit on bridges. While this is not a topic the student has a long-standing interest in, they may have demonstrated over time a true passion for the idea of structures. The student may be interested in the structure of numbers, spend hours using Legos® or blocks to build intricate buildings, and study the structure of the playground equipment during recess. These types of interests often need to be shaped with a student during the conference process so that they are able to see why you believe the “Bridges” Passion Pursuit might be the best match.

Length of Study: The length of time devoted to Passion Pursuits is very flexible. When the passion pursuit becomes a student’s full curriculum in either a school or home school setting, each passion pursuit will likely last four to six weeks (this provides time to complete all the included tasks, necessary research, evaluation, and any ideas that may emerge throughout the unit). When the passion pursuit will be the focus for three to five hours a week, it will take about ten weeks to complete. Teachers may adapt the length and amount of time that is spent on Passion Pursuits by adding or deleting items or modifying the expectations.

Community Resources: The resources in your school community as well as the larger community will in large part guide your Passion Pursuits study. Adults often have their own passion pursuits, disguised as a hobby or eccentricity. Not only do these adults serve as a valuable resource for a range of topics, they act as role models for the life long pursuit of passions in all types of areas. Create an internal list of experts by sending out a questionnaire asking teachers, parents, and connected community members to share any hobbies or special interests. You may discover that the math teacher has a life long interest in dinosaurs and travels during summer break to various dig locations. The reading specialist may have a large collection of vintage Barbie® dolls and accessories, and your school secretary may have completed a set of gourmet cooking classes. If you live in an area rich in resources in terms of field experiences or experts, you may find that much of a student’s time is spent working in the field. You may involve speakers and experts in addition to the print materials used for reference and research. Virtual field trips using the Internet also broaden the scope of the students’ experiences. If your school has a prominent fine arts department, the music and art teachers may take a role in guiding learners through some of the tasks and activities included in their Passion Pursuits unit.

Suggestions from Teachers:

Creating an Organizational System: Passion pursuits are ongoing investigations into topics of particular interest. As a result, learners accumulate many different resources, have projects in various stages, a range of materials supporting their work, and their Student Guide. One of the greatest challenges for teachers and learners is the organization of the materials. Each learner needs a designated space that will contain all the materials needed. Additionally, these materials need to be portable so that they may be easily moved from one work place to another. Copier paper boxes with the original lids or similarly sized plastic bins with lids create a good portable workstation. In general, these boxes will hold several different reference materials, project supplies and the Passion Pursuits Student Guide. Lists of tasks and materials lists can be taped inside the lids. Box tops can be used as trays to gather and carry materials. The box itself can be used as a small workstation. In settings where you will be re-using units as enrichment, boxes can be re-used by re-stocking any consumable items and can become portable independent study centers.

Gathering Resources: When Passion Pursuits is used by learners who have selected a specific topic for further study, the first step in the learning process is the gathering of resources. We recommend that learners utilize a variety of print and media resources. Work with your local library and librarians. Ask them to pull a variety of materials at the appropriate reading level of students. Ask for some higher-level resources to be included in the selection as well so that learners have a range of

resources from which to consult in their research. In addition to the non-fiction reference materials, ask that two or three fiction titles also be included. Each learner should have 10-12 print resources and supporting media resources such as videos, CD-ROMs, or posters. Begin your study by helping students to learn how to evaluate resources for quality and accuracy. It is critical that these skills be fully explored before learners are allowed to use the Internet for any type of additional research.

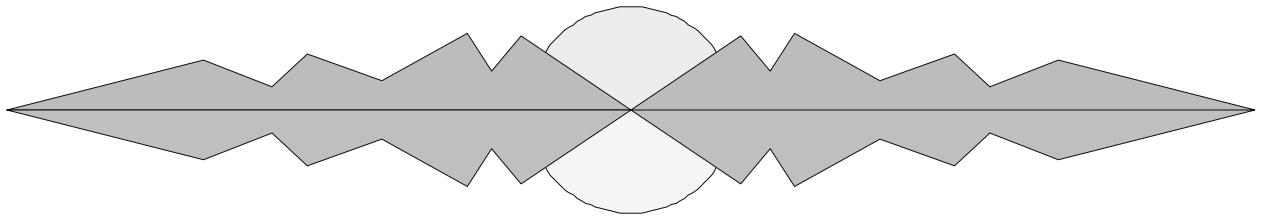
Encourage Sharing: Designate a special time and display space for student sharing related to their Passion Pursuits unit. Model the types of sharing you expect by bringing in relevant newspaper or magazine articles and samples of drafts and final products. Students should expect to gather and utilize critical feedback during the process of their Passion Pursuits unit. These sharing sessions may also spark new areas of interest in learners as they become exposed to a wide range of topics with which they may have little previous experience. Encourage family involvement by sending a letter home that describes the Passion Pursuits process and lists all of the different topics being explored. Ask families to share any areas of expertise related to the topics. Consider mounting a community board that documents some of the work being done by students in the various topic areas. Place a comment sheet nearby and encourage observers to add notes, suggestions, and offers of assistance. Be sure to include work at various stages to help inform the community of the process involved in the exploration of a personal passion.

Using Volunteers: When using Passion Pursuits with a full class or large group of students in a pullout or cluster program, it may be beneficial to utilize parent volunteers particularly in the early stages of the study. As learners begin the process of independent research, they may need assistance in successfully gathering the necessary information from various resources. While whole group lessons may provide the structure for this research, learners may initially need assistance in applying these new skills. Young learners may simply need support in reading the complex text that meets their intellectual curiosity as they learn more about an area of great passion and interest. Often, during the course of the study, learners will undertake a project or task that requires some adult support or supervision. Parent and community volunteers can be of great benefit during this time.

Allow Learners to Expand, Adapt and Develop Goals: While the included Passion Pursuit units (and those written for specific students) contain many valuable tasks and activities, learners often discover new sub-interests or projects they wish to do while engaged in their study. If a particular activity is very appealing to a learner, work with them to expand the idea. Encourage learners to suggest variations and alternatives to the designated research and selected tasks. Provide learners with a list of “products” to help them find areas of expression that are yet untried.

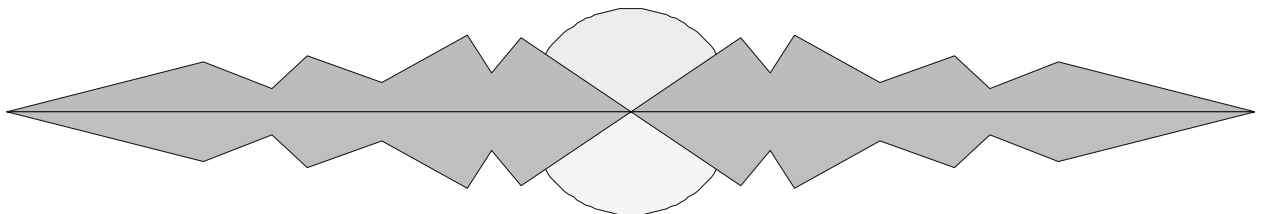
Assessment: Assessment is a built in feature in all of the various projects and activities. It is impossible to complete the tasks without adequately exploring the topic and completing the research. The quality of the product can be judged by learners through self-evaluation, by peers through critical feedback session, and by teachers using a general product rubric or set of expectations. Encourage learners to work towards personal excellence by using peer conferencing and feedback throughout their different processes. Provide time for revision. Encourage learners to self-evaluate their work both in writing and verbally. Ask them to comment on what they would do differently next time. Use interviews with experts and field experiences as opportunities to evaluate basic knowledge of the topic. Are learners able to prepare quality questions? Are they able to apply concepts and facts from one setting to the new knowledge being shared? Create rubrics by asking learners to share what they believe are the critical elements of a selected lesson or activity or by teaming learners to create their own.

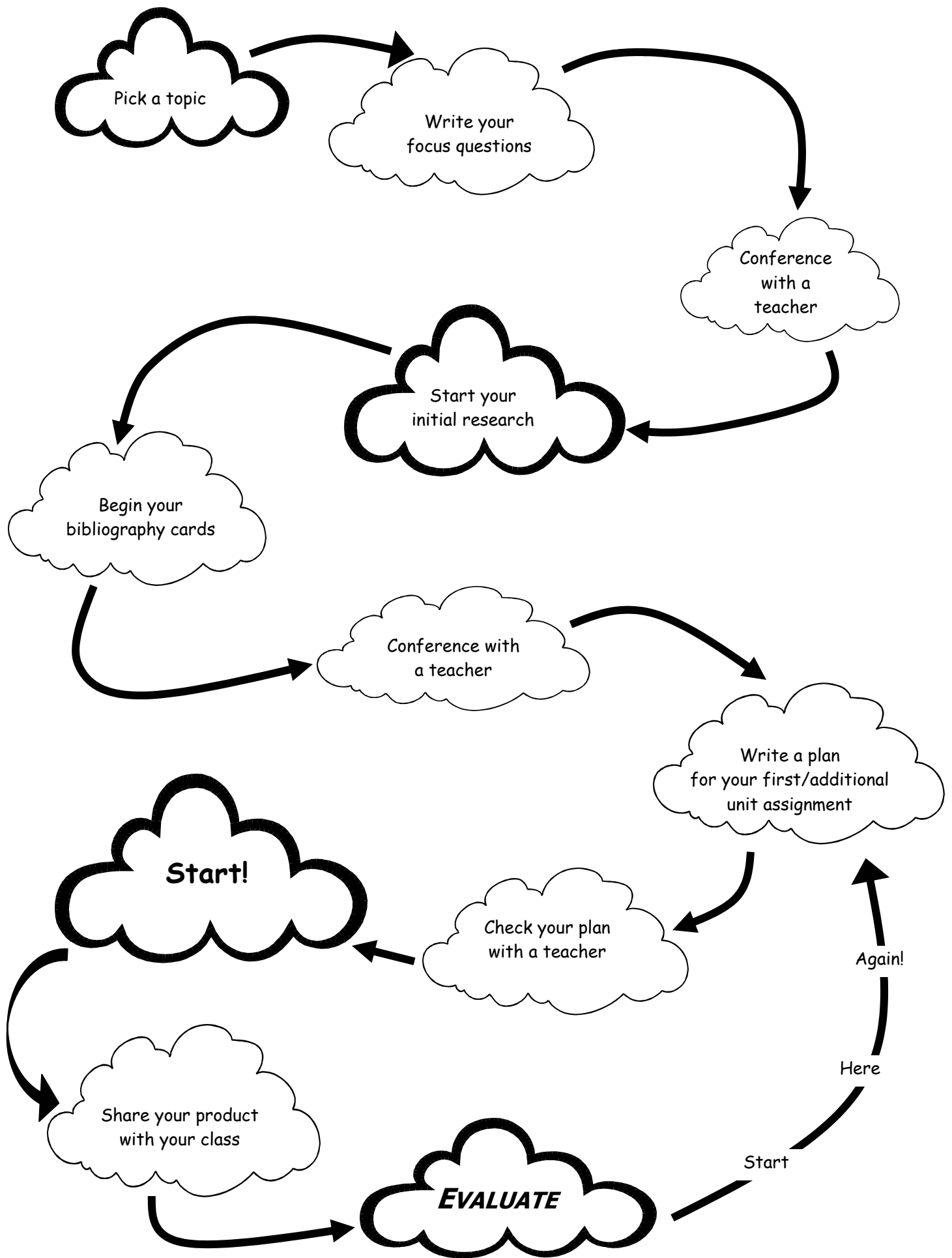
Passion Pursuits are a rich opportunity for gifted learners to explore their own multi-potentiality and offers a natural differentiation of curriculum Layered with complexity and opportunity, Passion Pursuits ignites a level of excitement and interest that provides a background for true life-long learning. We hope that your experience with Passion Pursuits brings as much enjoyment to your setting as it has to our learning community.



PASSION PURSUITS

STUDENT GUIDEBOOK





PASSION PURSUITS

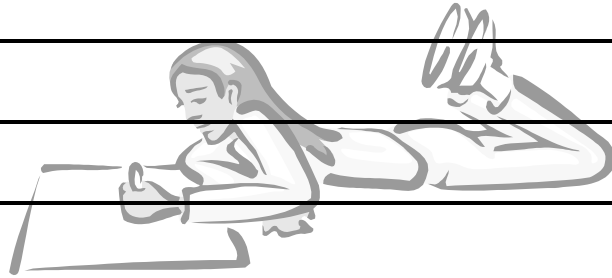


Picking a topic is the most important part of the entire process! You may already have some ideas that you are interested in learning more about or an area in which you would like to become more of an "expert". New interests are those which you know just a little about, but have a curiosity for learning more. Long term interests are those that you have always been interested in and that you know quite a bit about, but you would like to know even more! If you already have some ideas, list them below:

New Interests	Long-Term Interests	How long?

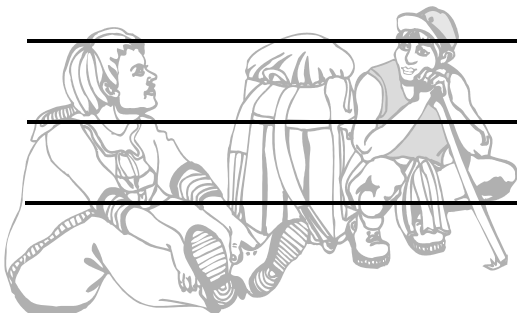
Now that you've given a little thought to some of your interests, it's time to start narrowing your ideas down. Use the following questions to help you as you begin to select your final unit topic.

1. What do you like to do in your spare time? When you have nothing planned for the day, what do you like to do? What is your favorite way to spend summer vacation or winter break?



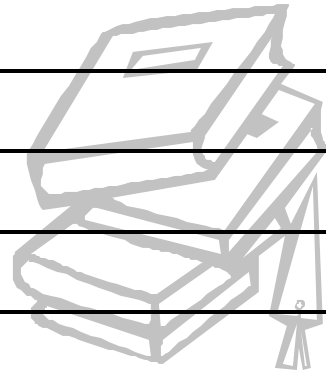
2. List any independent study projects you have done in the past.

3. What topics or ideas do you like to talk about with friends and grownups? What things do you have strong opinions about?

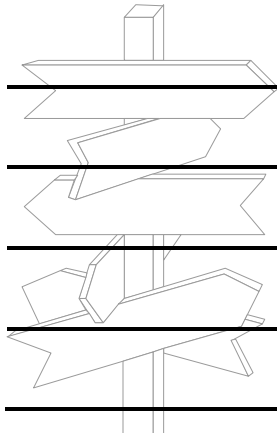


4. What careers do you think about? Do you have any ideas about what you would like to do as an adult? What kind of work seems fun to you?

5. When you visit the library or a bookstore, what types of books do you look at first? What is your favorite book of all time? Do you have a favorite computer software program?



6. Have you ever traveled? What was your favorite trip? Do you have any places that you dream of going to visit or live?



Work with a teacher to review your answers. Is there a theme or connection between your answers to the different questions? For example, if you like to construct model airplanes in your free time, want to be a pilot, and use a flight simulation program on the computer, you might want to consider selecting a flight related topic to research. Or perhaps you do Highland dancing as a hobby, will be traveling to Scotland, and have a favorite novel that is set in the area of Scotland. You might consider selecting a specific area of Scotland or time period in Scottish history to learn more about.

List any connection between topics below:

Compare these topic suggestions to your initial interest. Are there any matches? Work closely with your teacher to select your final topic. It is important to select something that will sustain your interest for several weeks. Pick the topic that you think is the best match for you as a learner.

Still can't decide? Do you have several topics, but none that seem to really interest you? At the back of your student guide is a list of different topics that you may want to consider. If you see one that really interests you, go back and try and see if you find any connections between the topic and the work you did earlier to try and narrow your focus.

Note here what the topic is that you have decided to study:

WRITING YOUR FOCUS QUESTIONS

Focus questions help you organize your research and guide your actual study. Focus questions are questions that you design before beginning your passion pursuit. These questions are "big idea" kinds of questions and generally can't be answered with a couple of words. In most cases, they can't be answered by reading one or two references. They are not "fact" questions. You will certainly learn many facts during the course of your study and these will be important to you in knowing more about the topic and creating your projects, but your focus questions will help you to make sure that the topic you have selected is rich enough for you to explore in depth.

Here are some examples of focus questions for a unit on dinosaurs:

- What kinds of education, background, and interests does someone need to be a good paleontologist?
- What are the strengths and weaknesses of the different theories of extinction?
- How do you really understand time, especially geologic time?

Use your topic to try and write your own Focus Questions. Review your questions with your teacher.

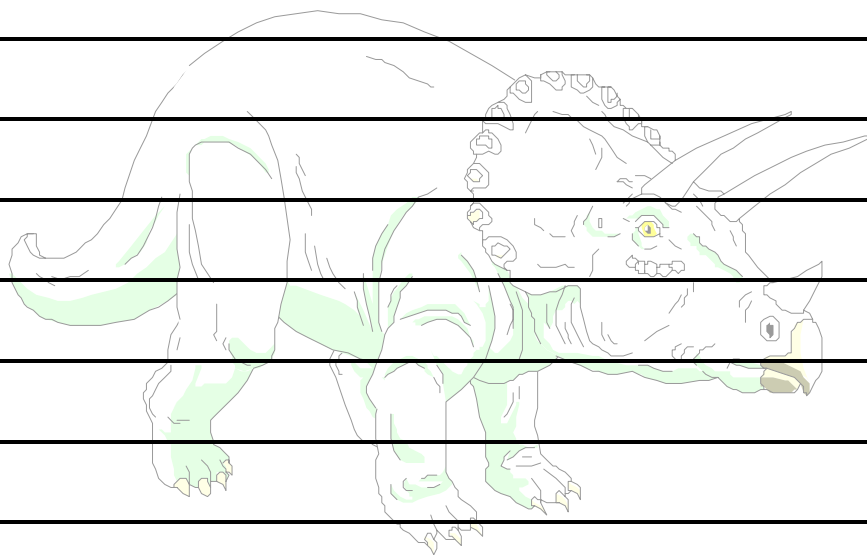
1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

4. _____

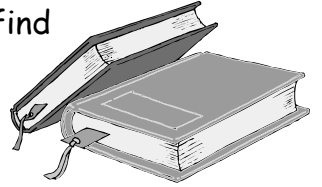
5. _____



FINDING YOUR INFORMATION

Where to Look:

Books: There are books about everything! Ask a librarian to help you find the section that contains books related to your topic. You can also do an Internet search using a book-selling site such as Amazon.com to learn more about the materials that might be available.



Encyclopedias: Look up your topic in several different encyclopedias including a computer encyclopedia. You may want to make a list of all the different words that describe your topic. Sometimes the encyclopedia has "cross-references." A cross-reference tells you to look under another word for more information. An encyclopedia gives you lots of general information quickly. The pictures and charts in encyclopedias may be very helpful to you as well.



Atlas: An atlas has lots of different information. An atlas is organized by "places." What places are important to your topic? Atlases also include information on weather, population, native plant and wildlife, transportation systems, and more.

Magazines: There are many different magazines. Some are about specific topics (like "Zoo Books" are all about animals). Some magazines have little bits and pieces of information about lots of different topics, like "Time for Kids." Ask a librarian to help you find information on your topic in various magazines. In most cases these are called periodicals and will be stored for a short time on the shelves and then older pieces will be in a computer or microfiche archive.

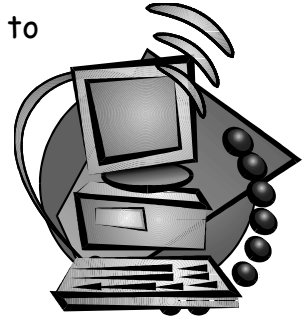


Newspapers: Ask adult friends and relatives to help you watch in adult magazines and newspapers for articles related to your study. The popular press often has good quality articles that interpret new findings or information. This can be a source for really up to date research.

Experts: An expert is a person who knows a great deal about something. Most people become experts because they are so interested in their field. Work with your parents and teachers to help find some experts in your topic area. Plan an interview with an expert to learn more about your unit topic from a different point of view.

Places: Learning about something first-hand is very valuable. Try to arrange a visit to a location where you can further explore your topic. This is called a field experience. Work with your teachers and parents to plan a field experience.

Internet: Many people rush to the computer when they are ready to begin researching a topic. The Internet is a quick source of information. Because there are very few restrictions on the information posted on the Internet, you will need to be a good consumer and carefully check with other resources to confirm information. When doing a search on the Internet, work with an adult in selecting key words and phrases.





There are many different ways to keep track of your research. Think about how you work and what you will want to know as you work on your unit. Will you want to be able to find the page of a certain picture later, or is most of your reading general knowledge gathering? Choose one of the two ways listed below (or suggest an alternative to your teacher) to keep track of your research. Most people choose to do a combination of the two!

Record Sheet:

Create a record sheet where you will list titles and authors of the books, magazines, and other resources you read or reference while researching your topic. This will help you remember which resources you used during your research, but will not enable you to find a specific quote, fact, or picture later. (An example "Read and Record" worksheet is included at the end of your guidebook to give you an idea of how to complete your worksheet. Use copies of the blank "Read and Record" worksheet for your record keeping.)

Bibliography Cards:

You should fill out a bibliography card if you think that a resource might be used again later. A bibliography is a list of sources you use to gather information. It is important to know what sources you use. This allows you to go back and check on something again or lets others learn more about your topic. Some people take notes on their bibliography cards as well so that they have all the information they need in one spot. If you will be taking notes on your cards, consider using different colored cards for different types of information. For example, you might decide to divide up your information based on your focus questions, using a different color card for each. Index cards also provide room for you to add a picture, drawing or diagram.

To make your bibliography cards use a small index card and include the following information:

Call Letters & Cataloging Information	Title of the resource Author Publisher, Date Published Location within resource Your notes
--	--

Title of web page Author (if given) Organization behind web site (if given), Date Published Date site viewed or accessed URL address for web page Your notes
--

How Do You Start?

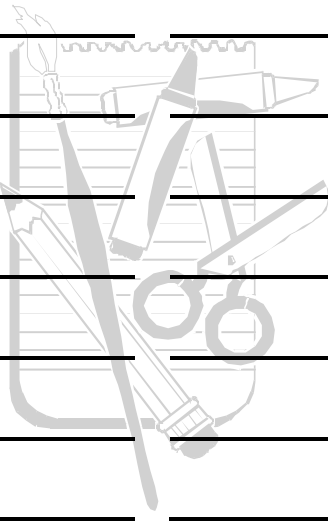
1. Do you understand the goal? When you read the goal, do you know what it is asking you to do? Break your goal down into several steps. What do you need to do first, second, third, and so on?

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____
4. _____
5. _____
6. _____
7. _____
8. _____
9. _____
10. _____

2. Write a rough draft, draw a picture plan, conference with a friend, make note cards—decide what you need to do to get started on your first step. Record this decision in the blank space below.

3. Make a materials list. (Make sure that you give your materials list to a teacher several days before you are ready to begin work on a project, and include things that you know are at school as well as those that might need to be purchased or ordered.)

Materials List

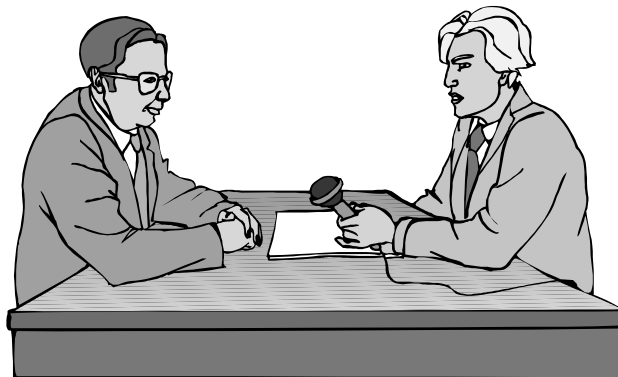


4. Decide how long you think it will take you to complete your assignment. (Set yourself a reasonable time goal; check it with a friend or teacher to see if they agree with you. Plan your time so that you can complete your projects. Make sure to stick to your time schedule and adapt it if needed.)
5. Gather your materials in one place (use your unit box to store materials).
6. Organize your workspace. This means finding a place where you can work. Find a place that has enough space for you to spread out. Make sure that your space meets all the needs of your project (for example: you should paint on tile, not carpet; your best handwriting should be done sitting at a table). Get all your materials out before you sit down and begin. Lay your plan out near you. Have a friend or teacher check your workspace with you to see if you have everything you need. Be ready to work for an extended period of time (with quick breaks for going to the bathroom, getting a drink, stretching your muscles).
7. Begin!
8. During clean-up make sure that you gather ALL of your materials together, including your plan, and that you put them away safely and neatly in your unit box. Leave your workspace cleaner than you found it!

PLANNING AN INTERVIEW

1. Telephone the person you wish to interview. Explain who you are and why you would like to interview her or him. (Use the "phone sheet" to help you before you make your call.)
2. Schedule the interview at a time that is convenient for the person that you are calling for an interview.
3. Make a list of questions that you plant to ask. (Don't be surprised if you don't get to all of them; sometimes you find out the most interesting things just talking to people.) Remember that the person you are interviewing doesn't know what you already know and what you would like to learn, so it is your responsibility to guide the discussion.
4. Take paper and pencil to the interview so that you can write down anything that you find out.
5. If you want to tape record the interview to listen to later in the classroom or to share with others, always ask permission first. Make sure that you meet with a teacher to test the tape recorder and get a clean tape before you go to your interview. (Many researchers use tape recorders to help them remember what they hear in interviews. This helps them concentrate on what the person is saying rather than on trying to write everything down.)
6. After the interview, write to the person you interviewed to thank her or him for their time. You should tell the person at least one thing that you learned and how you are using the information. You might want to invite the person to view your passion pursuit.

Want to interview someone but they live far away or are unavailable to meet? You can also conduct an interview by telephone, e-mail, or through letters! Some of the best experts in your field of study may live across the globe!



Phone Sheet:

It is very important that when you place phone calls to schedule either an interview or a field trip that you be well prepared. Take the time to completely fill in the following before you place the call.

Interview Contact: _____

Phone Number: _____

1. State your reason for calling:

"I would like to arrange a time to interview you. My name is _____
_____ and I am a student at _____. I am
doing a special study called Passion Pursuits on the topic of _____
_____. I am interested in learning more about _____
_____ and I understand that you are an expert in this area. I
would like to arrange an interview with you at time that would be convenient
for you."

2. Possible dates and times:

DATES

TIMES

****Circle the date and time that you agree upon.**

3. Confirm your arrangements including getting or giving directions to the interview site.

Interview Planning Sheet:

1. Name of the person I will be interviewing: _____
2. Topic: _____
3. Date and Time of Interview: _____
4. Phone Number: _____

Interview Questions:

1. _____

Answer: _____

2. _____

Answer: _____

3. _____

Answer: _____

4. _____

Answer: _____

5. _____

Answer: _____

6. _____

Answer: _____

Other Notes: _____

*Attach any pictures or materials you received to the back of this page

PLANNING A FIELD EXPERIENCE

1. Find the telephone number of the place you wish to visit. You could look in the white pages or the yellow pages of the telephone book. Telephone books are like dictionaries and are arranged in alphabetical order. You could also ask someone if they have access to the phone number.
2. Work with a teacher to develop a list of possible dates and times for your field trip.
3. Telephone the place that you wish to visit. Use your "Field Experience Guide" sheet while you are on the phone. You need to have a pencil with you when you make the phone call.
4. Fill out a "Field Experience Guide" sheet. This will help you organize your thinking before going on the trip. It has a section for your predictions and then a section that you fill out when your return to school. This is an important part of your record keeping.
5. Bring your "Field Experience Guide" sheet back to the classroom and let your teacher know what arrangements have been made.
6. Fill out a Field Experience permission slip to take home to be signed. You will work with your parents and teachers to arrange transportation to and from your field trip.
7. Go to your field experience and have a great time! Remember that you represent your school when you are out in the community.
8. Write a thank you note to the place that you visited. Make sure to tell them at least one thing that you learned and how you will use what you learned. If you worked with a specific person, you might want to invite them to review your Passion Pursuits projects when they are completed.



Field Experience Phone Sheet:

It is very important that when you place phone calls to schedule either an interview or a field trip that you be well prepared. Take the time to completely fill in the following before you place the call.

Place: _____

Phone Number: _____

Address: _____

1. State your reason for calling:

"I would like to arrange a time to visit your _____.

My name is _____ and I am a student at _____

_____. I am doing a special study called Passion Pursuits on

the topic of _____. I am interested in learning more

about _____ and I understand that this would

be a good field experience for me. I would like to arrange a visit on: _____

_____.

2. Possible dates and times:

DATES

TIMES

****Circle the date and time that you agree upon.**

3. Confirm your arrangements including getting directions to the site. Ask if there is a charge or if you need to bring anything special with you.

Field Experience Guide

What I am going to look at: _____

I think I will learn about: _____

Addresses for thank you notes:

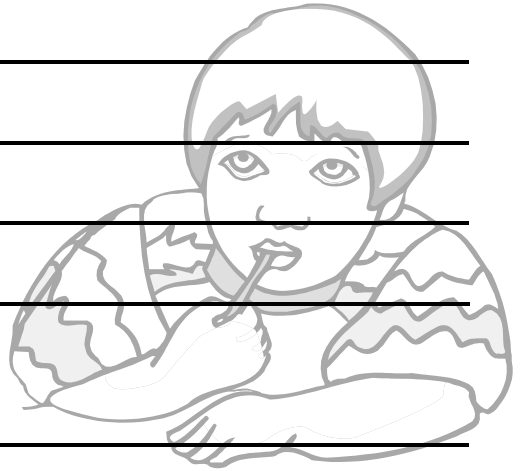
Field Experience Location: _____

Transportation Arrangements: _____

Date and Time: _____

Will the tour be: A Guided Tour A Self Guided Tour

Tour Guide's Name: _____

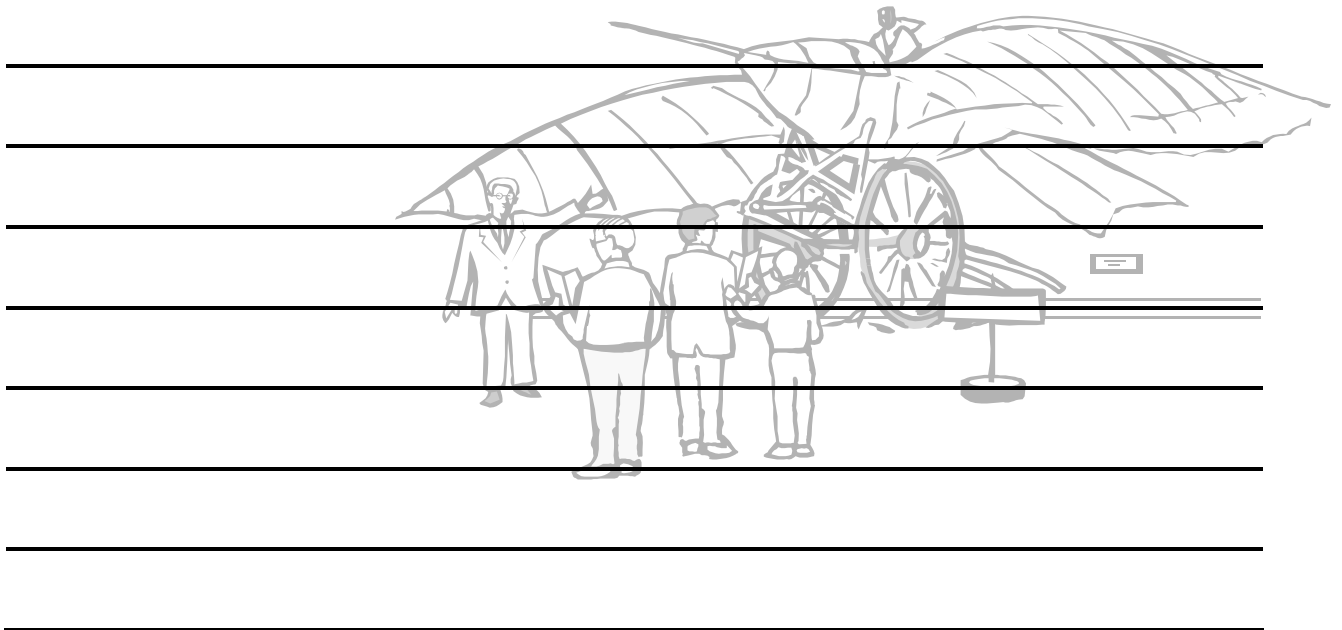


Field Experience Record

Three things I learned:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

Notes from my field experience:



*Attach any pictures or materials you received to the back of this page

The field experience was:

valuable

sort of valuable

not valuable

I learned things about my Passion Pursuit topic:

YES

NO

My behavior was:

Excellent

Good

O.K.

Not appropriate

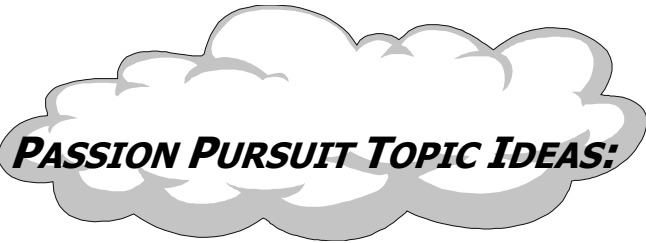
My escort for the field experience would say my behavior was:

Excellent

Good

O.K.

Not appropriate



PASSION PURSUIT TOPIC IDEAS:

The Amazon	Ancient Egypt	Ancient Greece
Ancient Japan	Atlantis	Arctic/Antarctic
Big Cats	Birds	Bookmaking
Bridges	Butterflies	Careers
Castles	Chemistry	Circus
Clothing	Clouds	Codes
Communication	Crystals	Daniel Minkus Pinkwater
Dark Ages	Dinosaurs	Dolphins
Dr. Seuss	Dragons	Drawing Cartoons & Comics
Dreams	Earthquake Resistant Buildings	Eclipses
Ecology	Electricity	Elvis Presley
Engines	Farms	Flight
Folk Tales	Future	Geology
Geometry	Ghost Towns	Global Warming
Greek Mythology	History of Baseball	Hospitals
Human Body	Ice Formations	Ice Skating
Illusions/Magic	Immigration	Insects
Kachinas	Kites	Knights

Logic	Mars	Masks
The Mayan	Medicine	Military
Money & Banking	Movie Making	Music
Mystery	Myths	Mythical, Magical Creatures
Names	Native Americans	Newspapers
Nutrition	Opera	Origami
Painting	Photography	Pioneers
Pirates	Plants	Ponds
Pottery	Presidents	Rabbits
Rainforest	Renaissance	Reptiles
Robots	Roller Coasters	Sculptors & Sculptures
Sea Animals	Seven Wonders	Shakespeare
Sharks	Sign Language	Simple Machines
Skiing	Solar Energy	Space
Special Effects	Spiders	Stand-Up Comedy
Sun	Theatre	Time Machines
Track and Field	Trains & Railroads	Veterinarians
Volcanoes	Weather	Wetlands
Whales	The Wild West	Zoos

EXAMPLE

Read and Record Bibliography Chart

This example chart is provided to give you an idea on how to complete your own "Read and Record Bibliography Chart" with information about the resources you consulted during your Passions Pursuits study.

Unit of Study: The culture of the Roaring Twenties

Books:

Title and Author	Page #	Notes
<u>Growing Up in the 20s by Renee Flapper</u>	<u>28-39, 45-65</u>	<u>Renee describes her job as a dancer in a nightclub</u>
<u>The Happy Decade by Tommy Author</u>	<u>28, 34-70, 89</u>	<u>Describes music tastes, changes in clothing standards</u>

Newspapers, Magazines, and Other Print Resources:

Title	Date	Page #	Notes
<u>"Birth of the Modern Swimsuit," Fashion Forward</u>	<u>March 2001</u>	<u>78-84</u>	<u>Pictures of swimmers in 1926</u>

Videos:

Title	Video Section (Counter number or time)	Notes
<u>"New York Twenty"</u>	<u>28.07</u>	<u>Black and white footage of dancers and night clubs in 1920s</u>

CD-ROMs:

Title of CD-ROM	Section of CD-ROM	Notes
<u>"Decade by Decade: The Twentieth Century"</u>	<u>"1920-1929"</u>	<u>Pictures, timeline of events</u>

Internet:

Title of Page	Site Address	Notes
<u>"Grandma's Journal: April 23, 1924"</u>	<u>www.grannysdiary.com/O4231924.html</u>	<u>describes a young woman's night out with friends</u>

Name: _____

Read and Record Bibliography Chart

Unit of Study: _____

Books:

Title and Author	Page #	Notes
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

Newspapers, Magazines, and Other Print Resources:

Title	Date	Page #	Notes
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____	_____

Videos:

Title	Video Section (Counter number or time)	Notes
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

CD-ROMs:

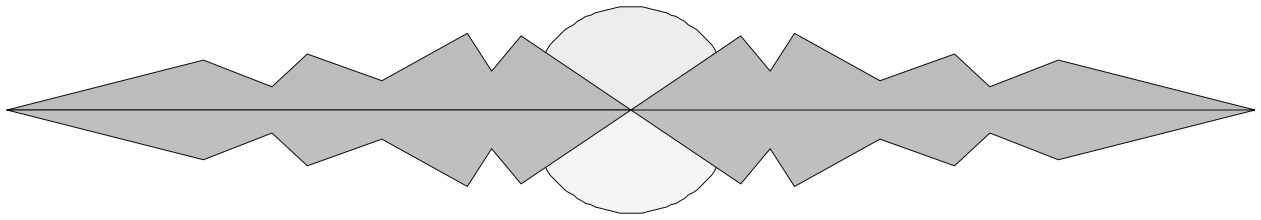
Title of CD-ROM	Section of CD-ROM	Notes

Internet:

Title of Page	Site Address	Notes

Other Resources:

Title of Resource	Location in Resource	Notes



PASSION PURSUITS

INDEPENDENT UNIT GOALS

INSTITUTE FOR THE DEVELOPMENT OF GIFTED EDUCATION
RICKS CENTER FOR GIFTED CHILDREN
UNIVERSITY OF DENVER

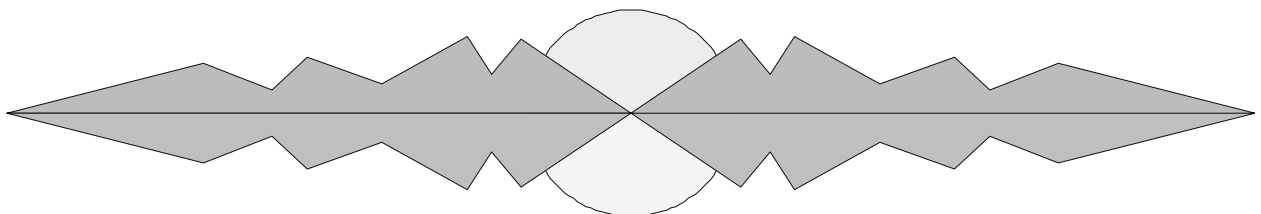
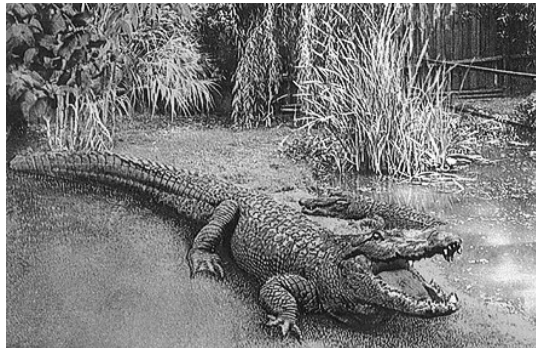


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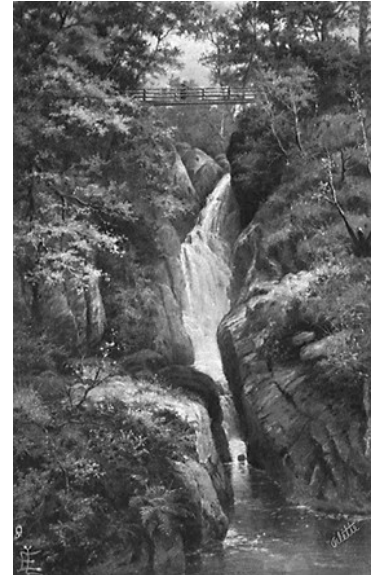
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THE AMAZON

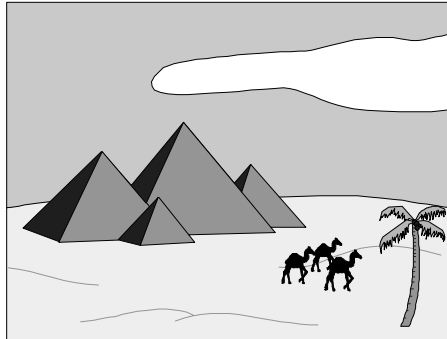


- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about the Amazon. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about the Amazon. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Amazing Amazon" chart.
- ☐ Make a salt clay map tracing the route of the Amazon River across South America. Color your map in realistic colors and carefully label the important points of interest. Add other three dimensional features such as small villages, clearings, animal habitats, and boats.
- ☐ Read about the many plants and animals in the Amazon rainforest. Use the book *Animalia* as a model for your own "Junglemalia" book. Include real Amazon plants and animals in the illustrations for your book. Your book should be at least five pages in length. Be sure to include an illustration of the plant or animal referred to on each page of your book. At the end of the book, provide a brief, factual description of each of the featured plants and animals.
- ☐ Read about the various problems currently challenging the resources of the rainforest and the Amazon River. Remember to include how these challenges affect the indigenous peoples of South America.
- ☐ Develop a series of solutions to address the more serious problems facing this region today. How will you decide which problems are the most serious? Which problem or condition affects human life? Which problem or condition affects the environment? How will you determine which problem or condition requires an immediate response?

- ☐ One of the characteristics of a rainforest is the amount of precipitation received each year. Create a chart that compares precipitation in your area with precipitation in the Amazon. You may want to do a monthly chart tracking the rain over the course of the year.
- ☐ Create your own precipitation by setting up an experiment to demonstrate how the rain falls in the rainforest. Gather several small, green plants. Place these in a shaded area of your classroom. Add other elements such as small plastic animals and housing structures. Create a structure that will support a large metal baking sheet over the top of the plants (large wooden blocks work well). Place a layer of ice on the tray. Now wait and see what happens! You will need to check your rainforest frequently. (To speed up the process of rainfall, place an electric teakettle near the rainforest, pointing the opening toward the baking sheet. Allow the steam from the kettle to heat the baking sheet.)
- ☐ Consider building a terrarium that can be used as a mini-rain forest. Visit a botanical garden, garden centers, and nurseries to find plants for your terrarium. You might consider including some small figures of people or animals that would be found in the Amazon in your terrarium.
- ☐ Create a large diorama using the information you have gathered during your research. Use a wide variety of materials in your diorama and include some three-dimensional objects.
- ☐ Learn more about the medicines that come from the rainforest. Create a chart identifying the native product and its uses.



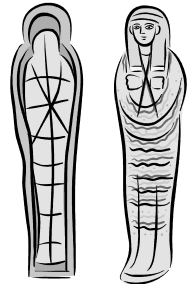
ANCIENT EGYPT



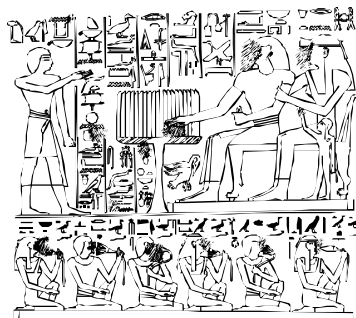
- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about Ancient Egypt. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read several books about Ancient Egypt. Select some general books on Ancient Egypt that are fairly short. This will give you a broad general base of information. As you narrow your interests, it will be easier to use more complex and detailed books on Egypt. Read and research all you can about Ancient Egypt. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Ancient Egypt" chart.
- ☐ Where in the world are you? Locate Egypt on a globe and maps. Using the map and the information you have gathered in your readings, make a list of the major landmarks of Ancient Egypt.
- ☐ Make a large salt clay model of Ancient Egypt and carefully mark each landmark. Use additional three-dimensional items to bring your model to life.
- ☐ Visit the Egyptian exhibit at a natural history museum. Learn as much as you can from the exhibit. Pay careful attention to the preparation and preservation of the mummies. Study the hieroglyphics. Can you understand any of the meanings? What is the Rosetta Stone? Why is it so important to the study of Ancient Egypt?
- ☐ Read *Mummies Made in Egypt* by Aliki. Using an old doll (Barbie® and G.I. Joe® figures work well) make your own mummy. Remember that the bodies must be carefully prepared for burial with oils and herbs. Read carefully to find out how many layers of cloth your mummy should be wrapped in.



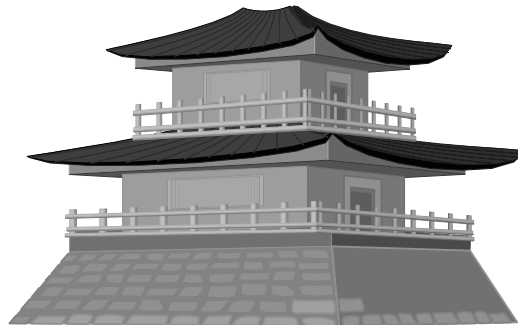
- ☐ Make a sarcophagus (mummy form coffin) for you mummy. To do this, cover your mummified doll in Vaseline and then papier-mâché the form. You will need to use many layers. After your sarcophagus is dry, carefully cut around the sides and remove the two pieces. Study pictures of different sarcophagi before decorating yours in the elaborate and beautiful Egyptian style.



- ☐ Use "How to Count Like an Egyptian" (from the book *How to Count Like a Martian*) to learn about the number system. Plan a lesson to teach the number system to your class. Prepare a math journal problem or page of problems to use after your lesson. You will need to prepare an Answer Key so you can check each math journal. Be prepared to help anyone who does not understand.
- ☐ Read *Hieroglyphs for Fun* or other books to learn more about this famous "picture writing." Make a chart or dictionary of hieroglyphic symbols. Include an introduction written in hieroglyphics that briefly explains the history and purpose of this written language.
- ☐ Use the game "Dinosaur Dig" as a model for your own Pyramid game. This will be a chance for you to combine all the things you have learned into an exciting game for others. Be sure to write clear directions for your players.
- ☐ There were many strong, famous women in Egypt. Learn as much as you can about your favorite female and then write a historical fiction story from her point of view. Refer back to your original readings to help you accurately depict the culture and environment of the time period.
- ☐ Create a mural showing an ancient Egyptian pyramid being built. *Pyramid* by David McCauley is an excellent resource. Carefully label all aspects of the process. Imagine that your pyramid mural will be on display at a natural history museum. Consider making your mural interactive to provide more interest to museum attendees.



ANCIENT JAPAN

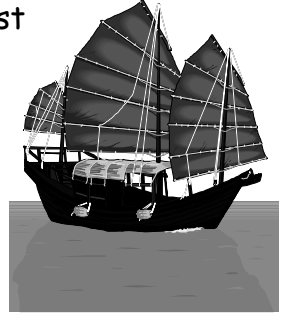


- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about Japan. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can on Ancient Japan. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Ancient Japan" chart.
- ☐ Make a world map with Japan clearly marked. Draw in the routes different explorers took to travel to what was then known as "The Orient."
- ☐ Read *The Thousand Paper Cranes*. Learn how to make an origami crane. Try making it with different kinds of paper. Make a mobile of all your cranes. Try to involve friends and family in creating cranes and see if you really can make 1,000 cranes.
- ☐ Make a Japanese meal for the class. You may want to interview someone at a Japanese restaurant to learn more about everyday and special occasion foods. Pay special attention to the "presentation" of the food.
- ☐ Make a chart showing all the different emperors of Japan and the time period in which they ruled. Include specific information about each emperor such as how old they were when they ruled, special things they did, etc.
- ☐ Make a poster showing some of the different Japanese characters (a character is the equivalent of our letters). Write your name using Japanese characters.
- ☐ Make a model bonsai garden. Many famous gardens in Japan surround temples. Decide if you will include a temple in your garden.

盛 夏

☐ Investigate different Japanese games. Make a model of your favorite game.
Teach your class how to play the game.

☐ Imagine you have traveled with European explorers on their quest to discover the Orient. Write a story about your experiences and adventures. This can be written as a personal journal being read by another person. Be sure to include your personal background, your journey to Japan, what you saw and did. Include your observations of the cultural differences between Japan and the European country you are representing.



☐ Contact a pen pal organization to arrange for a Japanese pen pal. Write to your pen pal and share information about your life. Ask your pen pal about their life in Japan. Consider keeping a scrapbook of the letters and pictures you exchange with your pen pal.



ATLANTIS



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about Atlantis. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about Atlantis. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Mystery of Atlantis" chart.
- ☐ Read several books about Atlantis. Some of what you read will be theories (ideas people think might be true) and myths and legends (fictional stories). Develop a rating scale (one for theories and one for myths). Use your rating scale to judge the different pieces you read.

Some examples of rating scales:

Theory

Definitely true

Could be true

Could not be true

Myths/Legends

Excellent

Good

O.K.

Bad

Based on your research, draw a plan of what you imagine Atlantis to have looked like. Use specific details from theories and myths you read. Using a variety of craft and recyclable materials, build a model of Atlantis using your drawing as a plan. Your city should be carefully labeled.

- ☐ Write your own legend explaining the mysterious disappearance of Atlantis. Look at other illustrated fantasies to get ideas. *Animalia* and *Dinotopia* are good examples. Create complex and exciting illustrations to draw the reader into the story. The journal technique in *Dinotopia* is another interesting technique you might want to consider. Imagine that you are a citizen of

Atlantis, documenting your experiences during the time right before, during and after the disappearance.

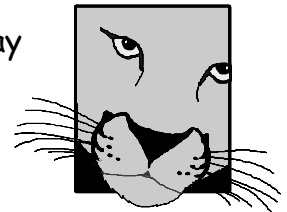
- ☐ Create your own game. Think about some of the games that you love to play. What are the elements that make these games exciting and interesting? Consider modeling your Atlantis game after a favorite, such as an Atlantis version of Clue® that explores the mysterious disappearance of the city. You should include a game board, directions, playing pieces, cards and a game box. Teach some friends how to play the game.
- ☐ Get a world map that you can cut up. Read about the Continental Drift theory. Cut out the continents and put them together as they were when they were one landmass. Is there a place to put Atlantis? Where would it fit? What shape would it be? Draw your version of Atlantis. It should be a size that makes sense with your other continents. Match coastlines very carefully. Mount your continents, including Atlantis, on foam core. Have other people experiment with putting the "Continental Puzzle" together. Write a brief summary of the Continental Drift Theory to accompany your puzzle.
- ☐ Plan an archaeological expedition to the site of Atlantis. Draw a map showing your destination. Pack a trunk with the things you think you will need for such a journey. You may want to contact someone in the Archaeology Department at a local university or museum for some advice. Use your "Interview Planning Sheet" to help you prepare your questions.
- ☐ There are many beautiful pieces of poetry written about Atlantis. It stirs the imagination of poets, artists, scientists and hobbyists. Select a poem that you believe evokes the mood and feeling of Atlantis. Memorize the poem to recite during Passion Pursuits sharing.



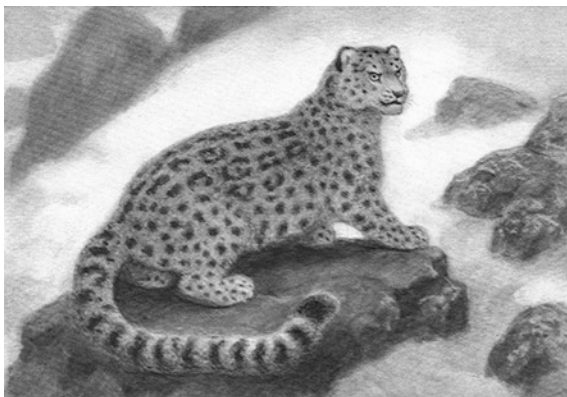
BIG CATS



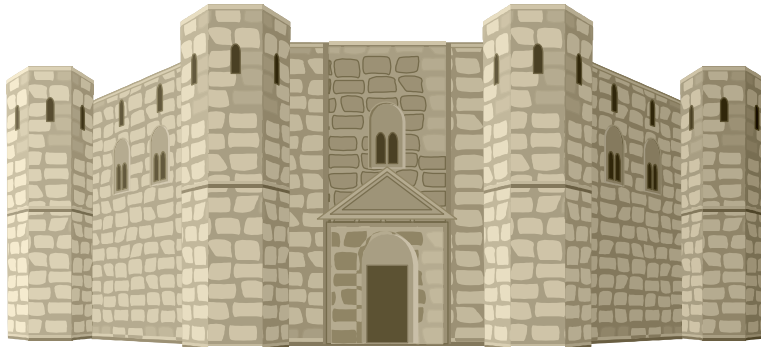
- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about big cats. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research as much as you can on big cats. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Big Cats" chart.
- ☐ Read Rudyard Kipling's *Just So Stories*. Pick one of your favorite big cats and write and illustrate your own *Just So Story*. Some ideas to try are:
 - Why the jaguar runs so fast
 - How the cheetah got its spots
- ☐ Make a mobile that shows all the different kinds of big cats. Use lightweight plastic toy cats, photographs, clip art, or your own drawings to represent the big cats.
- ☐ Make a chart comparing at least five big cats. Pick several characteristics to compare. Some ideas to consider are speed, habitat, and hunting habits.
- ☐ Make a diagram showing the eyes of the different big cats. Pay special attention to the pupil of the eye. Include a human eye in your chart. Explain the similarities and differences between all the eyes.
- ☐ Make a map of the world showing where all of the "Big Cats" live. Create a key that will help others to learn more about the location of the various big cats found around the world.



- ☐ Arrange a field trip to a local zoo or wildlife park to see the big cats. Make an appointment to interview one of the zookeepers. Prepare your questions before your interview. An example of some questions to ask might be:
 - Why are lions considered more social than other big cats?
 - How did the term "big cats" come into use?
- ☐ Compose a book of poems about the different big cats. Include things that are important or special about each cat. You can use free verse or one of the standard poetry formats, such as haiku, to create your book of poems.
- ☐ Create a menu for a restaurant that big cats might eat in. Include all the different kinds of food big cats would enjoy.
- ☐ Pick your favorite big cat. Make a puppet of your favorite big cat. Create scenery appropriate to your big cat's environment. Put on a puppet show for your class showing how your big cat spends the day and night.
- ☐ Create a dictionary of big cats. Include important information in your definitions. Be sure to include illustrations of each of the different cats in your dictionary.
- ☐ Design the "perfect" zoo habitat for your favorite big cat. Build a model of your design. Use your visit to the zoo or wildlife preserve to learn more about the creation of zoo exhibits.



CASTLES

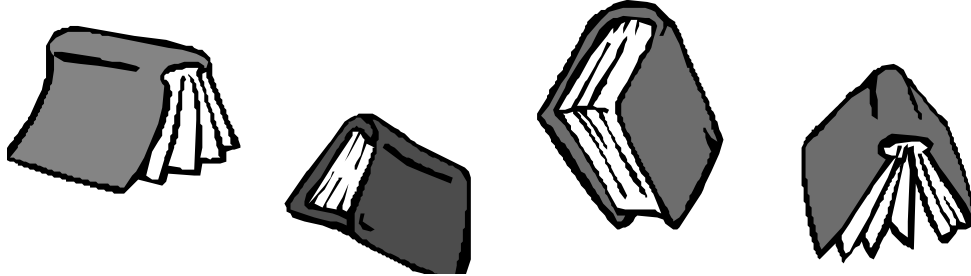


- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about castles. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can on castles. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Cool Castles" chart.
- ☐ Build a model of a castle. Use several of your favorite castles as a guide to creating your own model castle. Determine what size your final castle will be and select materials that are appropriate for your plan. Include all the common components of a castle.
- ☐ Make a floor plan of the inside of your castle. Carefully label all the different components. Use this as a key for those who will be examining your model.
- ☐ Many castles are still standing across Europe. Research the locations of these castles. Create a salt relief map of Europe and include the location of each castle. Create a guidebook that identifies and describes the special features of each castle.
- ☐ Read several stories about life in the castle. Most people think about knights, but they were only one member of a huge community that lived within the walls of most castles. Create a persona of someone living in a castle and keep a journal describing your experiences.
- ☐ Talk with a travel agent and learn about the different types of castle tours that travelers may join. Create an itinerary and budget for a castle tour. Use a spreadsheet program such as Excel® to develop your travel plans.

- ☐ Research the different innovations historians have found in their work on documenting the both the structure of castles and life inside the castle walls. Find a way to share with others your discoveries about these innovations.
- ☐ Castles have a dark, mysterious feel. Using descriptive phrases grounded in your five senses, create a poem about a castle.



Daniel Manus Pinkwater



☐ Read, Read, Read! Read as many of the Daniel Manus Pinkwater books as you can. Make sure that you write a brief summary of each book as you read it.

☐ Develop a rating scale to use with each book. You might make your scale more like a survey or you might make an "attitudinal rating scale":

A Survey:

- Did the book have good illustrations?
- Did the book have a great beginning?
- Did the book make you laugh?

Attitudinal Rating Scale:

This book was very funny.

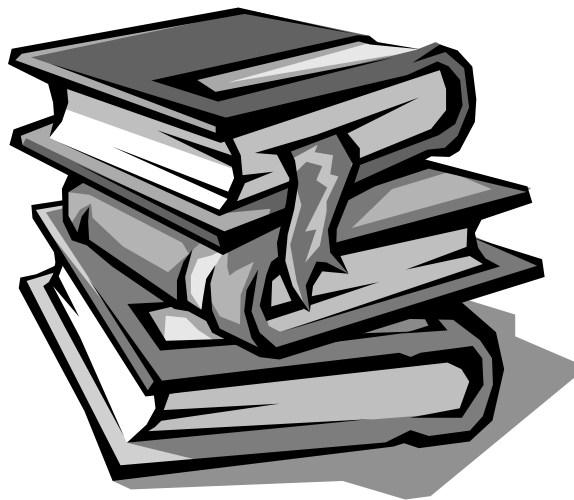
Strongly Agree Agree Disagree Strongly Disagree

Decide how to structure your rating system and create a form to be used with each book.

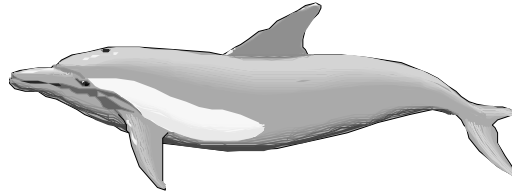
☐ Write to Daniel Manus Pinkwater. Usually, you write to the publisher and they will see that he receives the letter. This is a chance for you to tell him what you think of his books and what they mean to you. Use specific examples to let him know what you like and dislike. It is also a good chance to ask him questions that you can't find answers to in your research.

☐ Develop and write a short chapter book in the same basic style as Pinkwater's. Develop your own original idea. When you have completed your written manuscript, add illustrations in the same style as those found in Pinkwater's books.

- ☐ Select two of your favorite Pinkwater picture books. Read and re-read them out loud until you can almost tell them from memory. Record your stories on two separate cassette tapes. Create an appropriate set of puppets for each story. Use a pillowcase to make a story bag for each book. Add a cloth pocket to the exterior of the pillowcase. The book goes in a pocket on the outside. The objects and puppets to tell the story with and the cassette tape go inside the pillowcase. Add a drawstring through the hem of the pillowcase to use for closing the bag and keeping the contents safe. Decorate the outside of your story bag. Share your story bag with a class of beginning readers or a local library.
- ☐ Make a chart showing the similarities and differences between Pinkwater's books. Now make a second chart showing the similarities and differences between Pinkwater's books and Roald Dahl's books.
- ☐ Pretend that Pinkwater will be coming to a local bookstore. As Pinkwater's publicist, create a flyer, poster, and newspaper ad announcing the event. Think about what elements on each of the above would attract people to the event. First you will need to decide who you are trying to appeal to—is it other kids, parents, teachers? Design your publicity campaign based on these ideas.

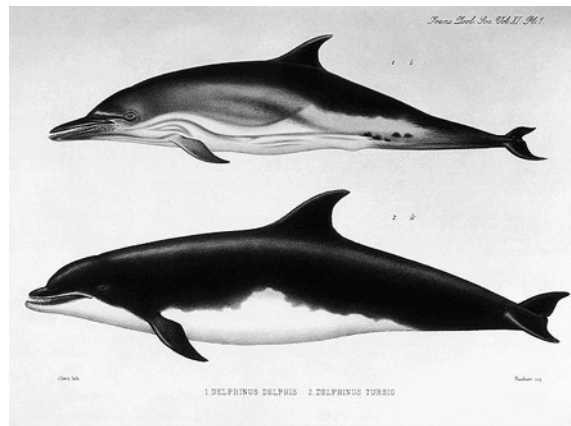


Dolphins



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about dolphins. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can on dolphins. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Dolphins Reading" chart.
- ☐ Make a diorama of a dolphin in its natural habitat. Determine the size of your diorama and then select a variety of appropriate materials. Include the plants, animals, fish and other mammals that might be found in the dolphin's habitat.
- ☐ Make arrangements to visit a zoo, marine park, or aquarium. If you are in an area that doesn't have access to a marine life exhibit, consider conducting a virtual field trip at some of the different aquariums around the country.
- ☐ Make a dictionary of the different kinds of dolphins. It should include pictures, the name, and some facts about each dolphin. Remember a dictionary is put together in alphabetical order.
- ☐ Make a non-fiction pop-up book for young children. Include your own drawings to accompany the story and textured "samples" for feeling.
- ☐ Make a chart showing an internal view of the dolphin. Include the various systems such as the skeletal system, respiratory and digestive system. You may decide that that you would like to create color overlays that will enable you to more clearly demonstrate all the system components.
- ☐ Conduct research on the Internet to learn about organizations that rescue and protect dolphins. Contact one of the organizations and ask how you can be involved in their projects.

- ☐ Dolphins are considered to be very intelligent animals in large part because of their sophisticated communication system. Learn more about how dolphins communicate. Try to find soundtracks of dolphin sounds. Using the soundtrack, help others to understand more about the system of clicks, splashes, and sputtering sounds that the dolphin uses.
- ☐ Create a large stuffed dolphin pillow. Decide whether your dolphin will be realistic or whimsical. Choose materials appropriately.



DRAWING CARTOONS AND COMICS



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about cartooning. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about cartooning. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Creating Cartoons" chart.
- ☐ Cartoonists draw five major kinds of cartoons:
 - Editorial or political
 - Comic strip, panels, and comic books
 - Gag or magazine
 - Illustrative and advertising
 - AnimatedTell about each type and provide examples of the first four types cut from newspapers, magazines, and other sources.
- ☐ Collect 10 examples of editorial cartoons from the newspaper. Pick at least 5 of them and explain (in writing) each one's meaning and relevancy to current events.
- ☐ Find out how a cartoonist creates a cartoon. Include how a cartoonist gets his/her ideas, develops those ideas and produces the finished cartoon. How is the cartoon or comic strip distributed? How will you show what you have learned?
- ☐ Try to interview a cartoonist. Prepare at least ten questions in advance for your interview.

☐ Research the history of comic art/cartooning. Make a timeline showing at least 10 significant dates.

☐ Do comics/cartoons affect the times in which they are created or do the times affect the cartoons? Explain and give at least 5 examples.

☐ Pick two cartoonists and research them and their lives. Tell about their training, their influences, and how they influenced the times in which they lived. Here are some ideas, but you should also pursue your own:

Bill Watterson

Charles Schultz

Al Capp

Dr. Seuss

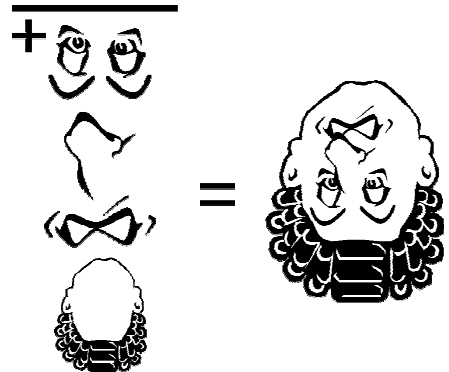
James Thurber

Walt Disney

☐ Read Chapter 1 in *Made in America* by Suid and Harris. Create a comic without drawing as outlined on pages 30-33.

☐ Try your own hand at cartooning. Keep a cartooning sketchbook. Feel free to doodle and experiment. Date your entries. A helpful book is *Cartooning: the Head and Figure*.

☐ Draw a week's worth of an original comic strip or cartoon. This final assignment should reflect all that you have learned about drawing, dialogue, comic plot and characterization.



Earthquake Resistant Buildings



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about earthquake resistant buildings. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can on earthquake resistant buildings. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Bouncing Building" chart.
- ☐ Interview an earthquake scientist to discover how various soils will react under earthquake conditions and what effect this will have on the buildings above. Before the interview create a list of 5-10 questions, and practice them with a friend. Finally, contact the scientist and arrange a time to interview them in person or on the phone. Write down the answers to your questions.
- ☐ Make a chart that shows the soil types, and describe how buildings erected on each soil type would react in the event of an earthquake.
- ☐ Interview an architect that designs buildings that will be erected in earthquake zones such as San Francisco. Before the interview create a list of 5-10 questions, whose answers will help you understand the kind of reactions a building undergoes during an earthquake, how soil type effects these reactions, and what design features are best to protect single- and multi-storied buildings during an earthquake.
- ☐ On paper, design to scale three building structures that use the techniques you have learned about. On separate pages describe which structure is best under which conditions and why. Choose two of your designs and construct models of the buildings. Carefully label the earthquake resistant features.

- ☐ Write two twelve line poems. The first poem should describe the feelings of a non-earthquake resistant building as it goes through an earthquake. The second poem should describe the reactions of an earthquake resistant building as it goes through the same quake.
- ☐ Create an advertisement for a paper in San Francisco highlighting your earthquake resistant building.
- ☐ Construct a globe and draw the major continents on it. Now mark where most of the major earthquakes take place. Which areas are most in need of special design features in homes or commercial buildings?



Elvis Presley



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about Elvis Presley. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can on Elvis. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Elvis Presley" chart. You will also want to interview fans, listen to his music, and watch videos. Make sure to find out:
 - Why Elvis is called the "King of Rock and Roll"
 - Where Elvis grew up
 - Who the important people in his life were
 - What movies Elvis acted in
- ☐ Take your information and write your own children's biography about Elvis. You might want to look at some good children's biographies to help you get started.
- ☐ Make a timeline of all the important events in the life of Elvis. You might want to make your timeline in shapes or in a song or some other creative form. Talk with your teacher to get some ideas.
- ☐ One of the most popular artifacts of the Elvis era are portraits on velvet. Work with the art teacher to create your own original velvet painting.
- ☐ Write to Graceland and the Memphis Chamber of Commerce to ask for information about Elvis, maps and schedules of special events. You might also ask if they have catalogues of the souvenirs for sale.
- ☐ Rent several Elvis movies to watch. Pick two and create movie posters for each to get people excited about seeing the movies. Look at some current movie posters at the theater to get some ideas. Carefully plan your space and choose appropriate materials.

- ☐ Make a set of Elvis paper dolls. Look through books to get ideas of many different kinds of clothes he wore. Make the clothes as detailed as possible. Put your paper doll set together in a nice box and label it carefully. Include a list of the contents and what the different clothes represent. Consider having an old and young Elvis.
- ☐ Learn several Elvis songs and practice performing these songs. Find things to create an Elvis costume. Make sure to practice curling your lip and dancing like Elvis. Now you are ready! Perform your own Elvis concert. Be sure to videotape this historic event!



FARMS



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about farms and farming. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about farms and farming. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Finding Out About Farms" chart.
- ☐ Using a large United States map, identify the different types of farms and farming that are found across the country. Make a more detailed chart focusing on the types of farming in your area.
- ☐ Select a type of farm (family farm, soy bean farm, corporate hog operation, cattle ranch, etc.) Make a large salt clay aerial model of the type of farm you selected. Use a variety of materials to make your model realistic. Label all of the different parts of your model.
- ☐ Try to visit a local farm. Remember that even in very urban areas there are often small farming operations specializing in specific products. Outside the busy Boston area are several small herb farms, small goat cheese operations can be found across the country, maple sugaring is common in the northeast and grapes are harvested throughout California. Share what you have learned with your classmates. Some ways of sharing would be pictures arranged in a display, or a video.
- ☐ Make arrangements to interview both a family farmer and a manager of a corporate farm organization. Use the "Interview Planning Sheet" to help you prepare your questions. Focus on the similarities and differences as you interview both people.

- ☐ Research what foods would have been included in a typical farm lunch in the 1950s. Prepare a menu based on your research. Next prepare a shopping list, shop for and purchase the ingredients, and prepare the meal you selected. Keep a record of how much time each step takes and the total amount of time the entire process takes.



- ☐ Create your own mini-farm of plants and animals that you can keep in your classroom. Keep a journal of your experiences.

- ☐ Select a time period in which you are interested. Make a set of paper dolls with costumes, animals, equipment and props. Create several backgrounds based on your research of farming in America. Examples of settings to include:

- The fields and crops around the farm
- The farmhouse
- The barn

- ☐ There are many songs about farms and farming. Pick five or six songs and make an illustrated songbook. Teach your class at least one of the songs in your songbook.



GHOST TOWNS



☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about ghost towns. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about ghost towns. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Ghost Towns Abound" chart.

☐ Using information you learned during your research, construct a model of a mining ghost town. Use a variety of materials and include as much detail as possible in your model.

☐ Read *Unique Ghost Towns and Mountain Spots* by Caroline Bancroft. Locate several close ghost towns and draw a map labeled with major metropolitan cities and the ghost towns you have identified in your reading. If any of them are in your state, arrange to visit them.



Other books to read:

- *Mountain Treasures* by Barker and Downing
- *The Central City Story* by Kamphausen
- *How and Where to Find Gold* by Ballanytne
- *Hidden Treasure in the Wild West* by Arnold
- *Roadside History of Colorado* by McTighe

☐ Arrange to visit an old cemetery. Call ahead to make sure you will be able to take the tour. Collect information and stories about people who lived in your area during the 1800s and early 1900s. Locate several gravestones from people who lived then and make one or two gravestone rubbings.

☐ Research the "modern ghost town"-Love Canal, New York. Present your findings to your class.

- ☐ Create the front page of a newspaper from the times of one of the ghost towns. Research carefully so the headlines, stories, pictures, and advertisements reflect those that would actually have been seen during those times.
- ☐ Chose one:
 - In a written story, predict what Tombstone, Arizona would be like today if the mine had not played out.
 - Imagine you are a miner in a boomtown. Write a diary that covers two weeks of events in your life.
- ☐ Create an anthropological site reflecting the life cycle of a ghost town. Using a large container of dirt, bury artifacts from the town showing its birth, boom years, and death. Bury the artifacts in appropriate depths and levels to reveal this life cycle.
- ☐ Write a non-fiction book for younger students on ghost towns. Include information found in your research and trips, pictures, etc.



GREEK MYTHOLOGY



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about Greek mythology. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read as many different Greek myths as possible. Consider asking an adult to read more complex versions so that you are able to listen for differences between various versions. Write a brief summary of the different versions of the myths on your bibliography cards to help you keep track during your study.
- ☐ Find out how the world began according to Greek mythology. How was the earth formed? How were the gods born? How were people created? Create a large mural to show your interpretation of the Greek version of the beginning of the world. Include all of the important characters and events in the story. Study other "story" murals to get some ideas for your mural. Plan your own mural on a small scale first.
- ☐ Find a piece of music that creates a mood that reflects the creation myth and your mural. Present your mural with the musical background as you story tell the myth.
- ☐ Make a poster showing the fourteen major members of Zeus' family. Organize your poster like a family tree showing the relationship between each family member. Include pictures of the gods and goddesses on your family tree, as well as a brief description of them.
- ☐ Choose a favorite mythological character (a goddess, god, creature or hero) and create a detailed clay sculpture. Carefully study illustrations of your character as well as written descriptions. Make a small sketch before

beginning. Greek statues are not painted so your details in the clay must show the complete image. Varnish your clay figure to preserve it.

- ☐ Many of the Greek myths have "morals" or lessons in their stories. A moral is a bigger meaning that goes beyond the characters and events in the story. Read the following myths carefully:

- Helios and Phaethon
- Bellerophon and Pegasus
- King Midas
- Eros and Psyche
- Orpheus
- Daedalus and Icarus
- Arachne



Try to determine the moral of each. Create a series of small posters sharing the moral of each myth. Are the morals (or lessons) as important today as the Greeks felt they were in ancient times?

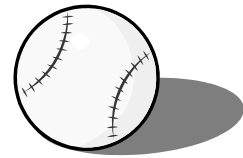
- ☐ Chose one moral that you think is still important today and write a new modern myth to share the lesson. Illustrate your myth and share it with another class. Are they able to identify the moral of the story?
- ☐ Create a model of the palace and labyrinth at Cnossus. Carefully read different versions of this famous myth as well as researching the archeological discovery in 1900 A.D. that might be the original maze. Include all of the important elements, especially the Minotaur.
- ☐ Hercules or Heracles, is famous for his adventures called the "Twelve Labors of Hercules". Create an accordion book showing the twelve labors of Hercules. Your book should be almost a wordless picture book with a brief caption or title on each page.



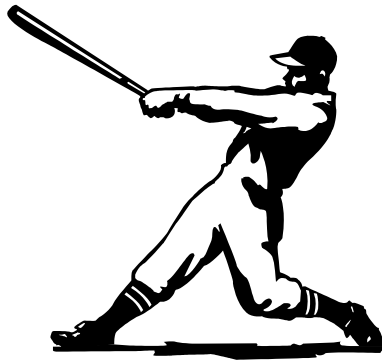
THE HISTORY OF BASEBALL



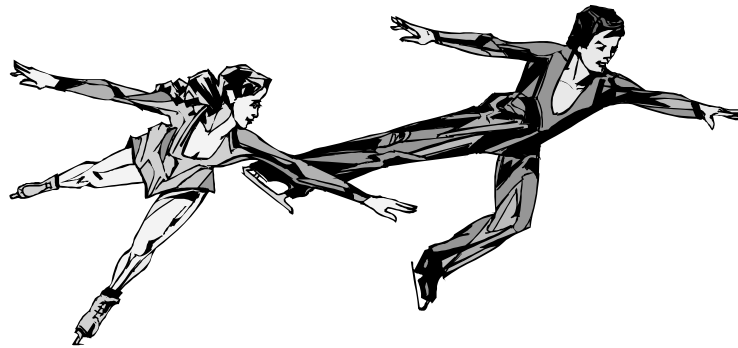
- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about the history of baseball. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about baseball. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "History of Baseball" chart.
- ☐ Make a timeline of the history of baseball. Include important events such as:
 - When and where the game was invented
 - Formation of minor/major league teams
 - Major statistical changes/events
 - First televised games
 - Major innovations/changes such as the Negro league and later integration.
- ☐ Create a "Baseball Hall of Fame" book or poster. Choose people throughout the history of baseball who you feel deserve to be in your "Hall of Fame." Write a brief biography of each player in your "Hall of Fame" including why the player was chosen. Include pictures in your book or on your poster.
- ☐ Interview an expert about major league baseball in your city, state, or region. Make a diagram that shows the steps a city must go through to get a major league team.
- ☐ On a large map of the United States, use baseball motif stickers to mark the location of all the current major and minor league teams. Include team names, colors and the date each team was organized.



- ☐ Set up an interview with a player or coach on your local major league baseball team. Write a story in the style of a sports reporter to share what you have learned. "America's pastime." Why do you think this is so? Interview several people and ask them if they agree or disagree (and why). Find a way to share the results of your survey.
- ☐ Decide where you think a new expansion team should be located. Support your decision. Make a recommendation for a team name, colors, mascot, and logo.



Ice Skating in the Olympics



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about ice skating and the winter Olympics. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about baseball. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Olympic Ice Skating" chart.

- ☐ Memorize the Olympic Creed. Share it with the class and help them learn it too. Explain what you think the Creed means.



Olympic Creed:

The most important thing in the Olympic Games is not to win, but to take part, just as the most important thing in life is not the triumph, but the struggle. The important thing is not to have conquered, but to have fought well.

- ☐ Go ice skating. Write a poem about your first ice skating experience. Have a photograph taken of you skating to include with your poem.
- ☐ Make a time line of famous Olympic ice skaters (focus on one field, such as pairs, men's, or women's skating). Your time line should include the skaters' names and dates of their Olympic performances and any special facts. Consider doing your timeline in a special shape, such as a string of skates on a figure eight. Be sure to identify significant changes and events in the sport of ice skating.
- ☐ Select your favorite Olympic ice skater. Find out everything about your skater. Write a biography for children featuring your favorite skater. Read

some other kids biographies to help you organize your book. Some good ones are *A Day in the Life of...* or *A Picture Book of...* by David Adler.

- ☐ If possible, tour one of the Olympic Training Centers in Colorado Springs, Colorado, Chula Vista, California, Lake Placid, New York or Marquette, Michigan. Use your "Interview Planning Sheet" to help you prepare your questions. Example questions include:

- What is a daily training schedule like?
- How do athletes build their strength and speed?
- What specific events do female skaters compete in?
- What does it take to become an Olympic champion?

If it is not possible to physically visit a training center, view the U.S. Olympic Team web site at <http://www.olympic-usa.org> to learn more about training for the Olympics.

- ☐ Create a training schedule for yourself. Be sure to include menus that reflect your goals as an athlete.

- ☐ Make a wire sculpture of a skater performing. You might consider doing a sequence that shows the skater at several different times during the performance.

- ☐ Select a piece of music that could be used in either the short or long program competition. Do a basic plan of the choreography for the piece. Be sure to include the required elements.



ILLUSIONS/MAGIC



☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about illusions and magic. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about illusions and magic. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Incredible Illusions" chart.

☐ Make a chart that tells about five different types of magic. Your chart should be in color. Some things you will want to include are:

- A title
- Labels for each type of magic
- A description of each type of magic
- Some examples of each type of magic
- The names of magicians who performed each type of magic
- A list of some of the materials used for each type of magic
- Illustrations that help support your descriptions or examples

Five kinds of magic you might want to include are:

- Sleight-of-hand
- Close-up
- Illusions
- Escape
- Mentalist

☐ Make a timeline that shows when famous magicians and illusionists lived, special or unique acts of illusion they created, and where they performed. Consider using a creative format for your time line such as the basic dates

on a series of black hats with white rabbit cut outs filled with more information about the illusionist or special tricks.

- ☐ Make arrangements to visit a specialized toy store or magic shop. Arrange to interview the store manager or owner if possible. You may also want to try and meet with a local magician or illusionist. These people are often listed in parenting publications for birthday party entertainment and can sometimes be found in the yellow pages under "Entertainment." Use your "Interview Planning Sheet" to help you prepare your questions.
- ☐ Choose a stage name, design a costume, and learn several magic tricks. Organize an act and put on a magic show for your class. Use the "Practice-Perfect-Perform" guide to prepare for your performance.
- ☐ Make a poster to advertise your magic show. Make a list of all the information that needs to go on the poster. Plan your space carefully and design a poster that will get people excited about coming to your magic performance. Produce your poster!
- ☐ Select your favorite magician or illusionist. Research this person and then write a children's biography. You might want to read some of the *Day in the Life of ...* or *A Picture Book of ...* by David Adler to help you get started.
- ☐ There are many different famous illusionists and magicians working around the world. Learn more about some of the current illusionists and magicians by researching on the Internet. Select one that particularly interests you and write a letter asking for any information or guidance that he/she might be able to give to a "budding" magician.

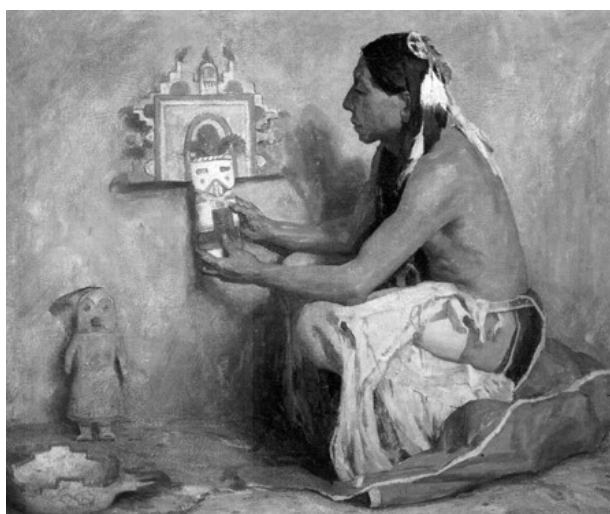


KACHINAS

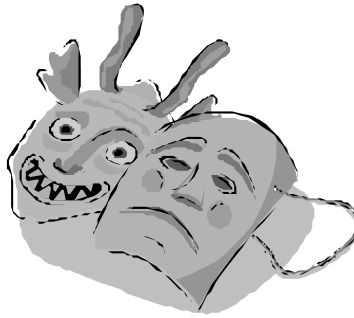


- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about kachinas. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about kachinas. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Kachinas" chart.
- ☐ Make a timeline of the Hopi American Indians. Include important events such as when they first used kachinas, and developed weaving and silverwork. Include outside influences such as trading with other tribes, trading with settlers, and changes in the environment.
- ☐ Make a display of four different kachinas. Use photographs, drawings and/or real dolls as references. Label your display. Include information about the purpose, symbols, materials used, and special characteristics of each kachina.
- ☐ Visit a natural history museum and/or an art museum to view the kachina doll displays. Record your experience in a journal. Summarize your experience in a tape recording that classmates can listen to.
- ☐ Research the symbols used by the Hopi Indians. Create a poster or mural to display the different symbols used by the Hopi Indians. Label each symbol and explain what the symbol means and how/when it was used.
- ☐ Create a large map of the area where the Hopi Indians live. Include the names of neighboring tribes. Consider making a three-dimensional map by adding real elements to the map, such as a small basket, or Fun Foam[®] representation of a kachinas.

- ☐ Design and build your own kachina doll. What spirit does it represent? What is its story? How does it help people? Write a story and create a dance for your kachina doll. Share this with your classmates.
- ☐ What role do kachinas play in current Hopi culture? Record your thoughts in a journal entry. This can be done as a narrative or in the form of a poem or song.



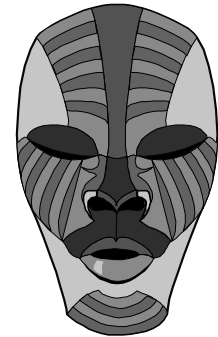
MASKS



☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about masks and mask making. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about masks and mask making. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Marvelous Masks" chart.

☐ Pick five different cultures that used or made masks. Research how masks were used in each of these cultures. Create a mural that shows:

- an example of a mask from each culture
- a written explanation of how the mask was used
- a list of materials used to make each mask
- a written explanation of what each mask represents



☐ Research masks by visiting different art galleries, natural history museums, and art museums. Make sketches of the different masks you find. Include notes on the culture and purpose of each mask. Note which of the masks are currently made and which are historic masks.

☐ Pick three different cultures or time periods that used masks. Look at as many examples of these masks as you are able to find. Now make three masks that represent each of the cultures or time periods you selected. Your style and materials should be as close as possible to the original masks.

☐ Pick one of the masks you have made and write a legend to go with it. If it is to be used in a ceremony, include the song, chant or dance that goes with the mask.

- ☐ Design a mask making kit complete with written instructions. Give your kit to someone special so they can make a mask too! You might want to read some books on making masks to help you get started.
- ☐ Create your own special mask. Be as creative as you can! Refer to the information you gathered in studying different cultures and mask to help you create a mask that represents you.



MILITARY



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about the different branches of the military. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about military. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "More About the Military" chart.
- ☐ Make a separate timeline for each of the military branches. Focus on the inception of each branch. Try to identify the purpose of each branch. Consider creating the timelines using shapes or colors that represent each branch. For example, the Navy timeline might be done on a series of ships. The ships might represent advances in the vessels over the course of time.
- ☐ Visit the recruiting offices of the different military branches. Plan to interview a recruiting officer at each office. Collect any brochures or other informational material that is available.
- ☐ Contact the Public Relations Office of your favorite branch of the military. Arrange an interview with a career military officer.
- ☐ Using a large map of the United States, identify all of the major military bases. Use the appropriate military insignia to designate which branch of the military is primarily stationed at each base. Include a brief explanation of the types of activities that take place on each base.
- ☐ Each branch of the military has a distinct creed. Learn about these "rules of conduct" or expectations. Find a way to share these with your peers.



- ☐ Create posters representing and explaining all the components of the uniforms of each branch of the military. Use similar ranks to create a more accurate comparison. Consider asking for photos of women/men in uniform at the recruiting offices to use for reference.
- ☐ Work with an adult to read excerpts of *The Greatest Generation* by Peter Jennings. This book describes some of the experiences of those involved in the WWII effort. This war has often been called the "big one" or the "great one." Learn more about how the different branches worked together and separately to accomplish a single goal.
- ☐ Create an alphabet book focusing on different aspects of all branches of the military. You might want to pick a theme, such as "equipment of the different branches of the military" or "changes in the military in the last 100 years" to help you organize both your research and your finished book.
- ☐ There are many excellent models of different military vehicles. Consider building a different vehicle or piece of large equipment for each branch of the military (for example a submarine for the Navy, an Air Force aircraft).



MONEY AND BANKING

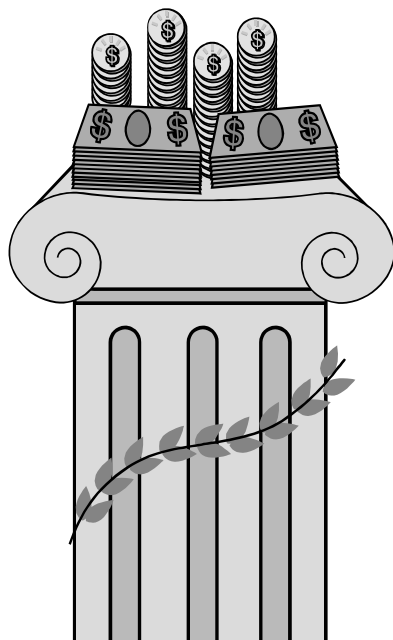


- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about money and banking. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about money and banking. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "More about Money" chart.
- ☐ Write a letter to the Federal Reserve Bank and request a copy of "The Story of Banks". Research the proper form used to write a business letter.
- ☐ Make arrangements to visit a bank that specializes in helping young clients develop good money management and banking skills. Use the "Interview Planning Sheet" to help you prepare for your visit. In addition to learning about the services offered and the basic operation procedures of the bank, be sure to ask about the different careers available in the banking industry.
- ☐ Make arrangements to visit or do a virtual tour of a mint. There are three different mints around the country specializing in different areas of currency. Locate these mints on a map and try to determine how the locations were selected.
- ☐ Make a chart that shows how a coin is made. Use the information you gathered in your research on mints as well as other research you have conducted.
- ☐ Create a timeline that shows the history of money. Historically, money has been anything that helps you get other things. Read the book *Money, Money, Money* to help you get started.
- ☐ Write a children's book about the different jobs people do in a bank. Your book should include:
 - The names of the jobs
 - A description of what each person does

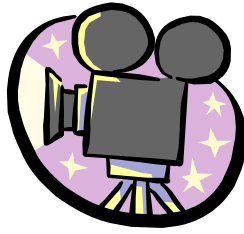
- Why the job is important to the bank
- Illustrations of people performing the tasks of their job (a teller counting money)

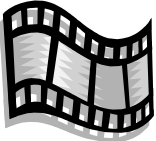


Contact a variety of financial institutions by phone and conduct a survey of the services each institution offers. Create a display board comparing the different institutions' services.

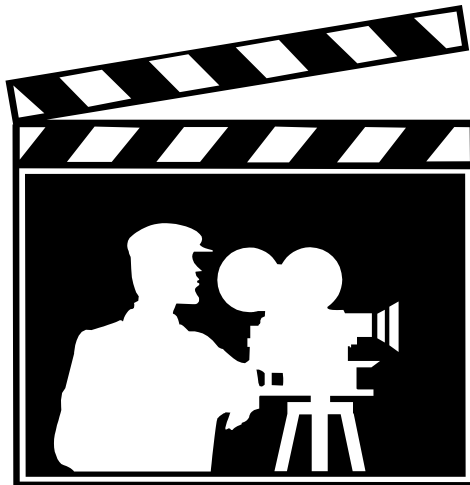


MOVIE MAKING



- ☐ Search your public, school, and classroom libraries and at home for any books about movie making. Also search for information on the Internet. Read and research all you can about movie making. Keep a bibliography of all the books you read and the Internet sites you visited. Record this information on your "Hollywood Walk" chart.
- ☐ Write a 1-2 page story that could be used as a basis for a movie. The story should have only 2-3 characters; this will allow greater plot development. Your story should be very descriptive when referring to the location. It should also have enough action to keep the reader's (and eventually viewer's) interest.
- ☐ Interview a movie critic. First prepare a list of interview questions, and then practice them with a friend. Finally, contact a local movie critic and arrange a time to talk in person or by phone.
- ☐ Read several movie reviews in the local newspapers or watch a movie critic on television. Rent several different types of age appropriate movies, and then write 2 movie reviews of your own. 
- ☐ Research the early history of movies. Make a flip chart movie based on your research.
- ☐ Using a video camera, make a one minute "claymation" movie. Kits are available for purchase that will help you make a claymation movie.
- ☐ Create a survey and interview 5-10 people about their top five movie picks. Be sure to ask why they picked the films they did. After you have gathered your information, analyze your data. Are there any common films listed? Even if the movie titles are different, were any of the reasons people gave for picking their movies the same?

- ☐ Arrange to visit a projection booth at a local movie theater. Independent movie houses may be more willing to let you visit. Draw a diagram of the projection booth and the projectors. Explain how the projectors work. Explain what a projectionist does.
- ☐ Write a script based on the story idea you created earlier. Use your script to create a storyboard. Your storyboard will identify the location, the entrances and exits, the blocking, the non-verbal action, and costume and prop suggestions. Your piece should be approximately 5–7 minutes in length. Rehearse and film a 5-7minute movie based on your script and storyboard.
- ☐ Create a poster and newspaper advertisement for your movie. Make a list of all the information that needs to go on the poster. Plan your space carefully and design a poster that will get people excited about coming to your movie performance. Produce your poster! Examine several different movie ads in a local newspaper; what does your ad need to contain to get people interested in viewing your movie?



MYTHICAL, MAGICAL CREATURES



☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about mythical, magical creatures. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about mythical creatures. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Magical Mythical Creatures" chart.

☐ Create a pictictionary of mythical, magical creatures. Your pictictionary should include the name of the creature, background history and legend and an illustration. Some literary figures to include are Grendel from "Beowulf", Charybois and Scylla from the "Odyssey" and Smaug from *The Hobbit*. Some other magical creatures to explore:

- | | |
|----------------------|------------|
| • Abominable Snowman | • Cyclops |
| • Harpies | • Hecate |
| • Loch Ness monster | • Phoenix |
| • Satyrs | • Scylla |
| • Vampires | • Werewolf |



☐ Write a book based on *Fortunately, Unfortunately*. Use a dragon as the starring character. Try to imagine the advantages and disadvantages of being a dragon.

☐ Create a mythical creatures museum. Find examples of famous artwork to include in your museum. Make sure you include the title of the piece and the artist. Use a wide range of techniques and materials to create your own

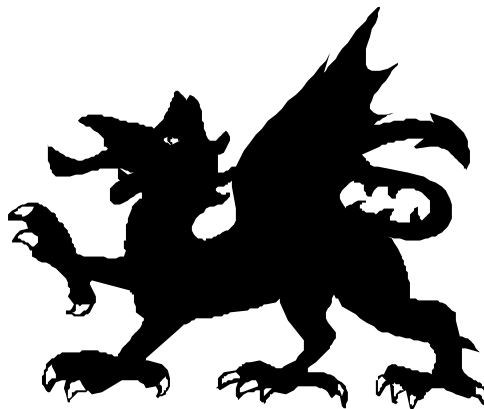
original artwork. Try some sculpture, painting, pen and ink drawing, quilting, and jewelry making.

☐ Find a copy of "The Jabberwocky" by Lewis Carroll and "The Unicorn" by Shel Silverstein. Memorize both poems and recite them to your classmates. You may want to select some music to play in the background.

☐ Find out all you can about unicorns. Write your own fiction story about a unicorn. You may want to look at Michael Green's *Unicorn Notebook* and the Serendipity books about Morgan before you begin. Publish your story and create a story bag to go with your book. (A story bag can be made using a pillow case and adding a draw string through the hem. Create a pocket on the outside of the bag for the book. Add a cassette tape of you reading the story aloud—be sure to practice! Add props such as stuffed animals, puppets and small toys.) Share your story bag with a class of beginning readers or a local library.

☐ Use *The New Games Book* and learn to play "Capture the Dragon's Tail" and "Smaug's Jewels". Teach your class how to play both games. Knowing all you know about mythical, magical creatures can you create a new "New Game"? Try out your own game and make any modifications. Send your idea to the New Games group.

☐ Rent the movie "Legend" to watch. Write a review for your class newsletter or family paper. You should read some movie reviews in the newspaper before you begin. What are some essential elements of a movie review?



OPERA



☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about opera. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about mythical opera. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "The Joys of Opera" chart.

☐ Opera is perhaps the most complex of all art forms. To better understand opera, research and explain the following terms. Choose a creative approach to display what you have learned.

- Aria
- ensemble
- Libretto
- Oratorios
- Score
- bel canto
- Grand opera
- opera buff
- recitative
- singspiel
- Coloratura
- leitmotif
- Opera seria
- repertoire
- Verismo
- The word opera comes from the Italian phrase "opera in musica." What is the meaning of this phrase? What is the general meaning of opera?
- What is meant by libretto? Why might libretto be difficult to understand? Why is it written as it is? What purpose does it serve?

☐ Voice ranges are classified into various groups such as soprano, alto, tenor, baritone, and bass. There are also variations such as mezzo soprano and contralto. Discover what range each voice type has. Record a sample of singers' voices to demonstrate each type.

☐ Many people are involved in producing an opera. Study these necessary jobs. If possible, arrange to meet and interview these people. Prepare a report of your findings.

- Choreographer
- Costume Designer
- Set Designer
- Chorus Master
- Librarian
- Singer
- Conductor
- Prompter
- Stage Director

☐ Opera originated in the 16th century in Florence, Italy with the coming together of poets, musicians and aristocrats. Trace the historical development of this art form over the years in a media form of your choice.

☐ Choose an opera to study in detail. Research the story and listen to the music. Listen to several different artists performing this opera. Do you detect different vocal interpretations?

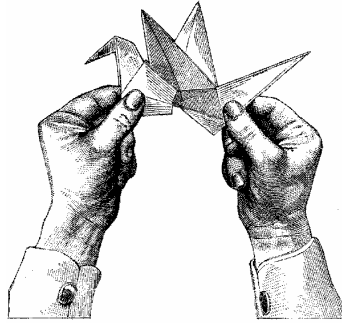
☐ Design a costume that would be appropriate for a character in this opera. Create two or three set designs representing scenes from this opera.

☐ The philosopher Voltaire once wrote, "The opera is a spectacle as outlandish as it is magnificent, where the eye and the ear are more satisfied than the mind, where the fact that everything has to be set to music causes the most ridiculous situations, where they sing while a town is being destroyed, and dance around a tomb." Interpret this passage in your own words. Do you agree with Voltaire? Why or why not?

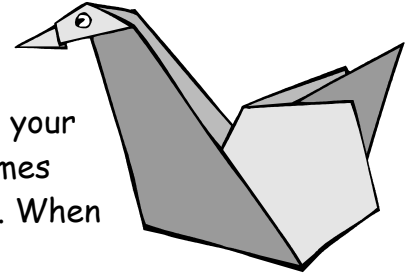


☐ Select a composer or singer to research. Make a presentation to your class as if you were that person. Talk about your contributions to the world of opera. Dress in the style of this person. Accompany your presentation with examples of his/her music.

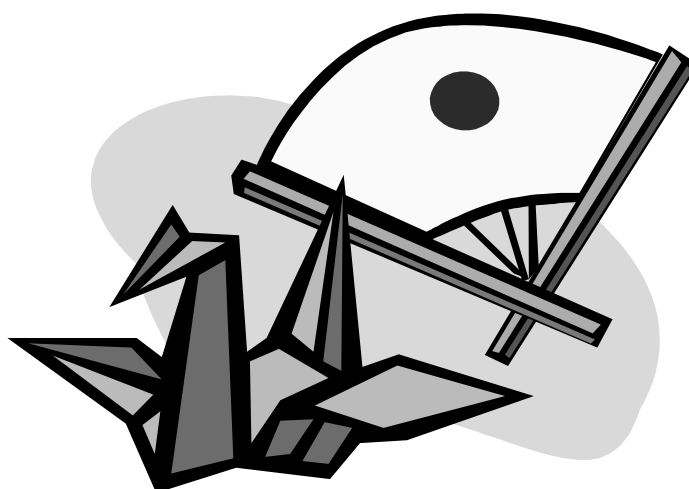
ORIGAMI



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about origami. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about origami. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Outrageous Origami" chart.
- ☐ Conduct research on origami so you are able to answer questions about origami. How did it start? Where was origami first done? How is it used today? Are there "masters" of origami? How is it learned? How is origami related to math? Write your own children's book that will teach others what you have learned.
- ☐ Read *Sadako and the Paper Cranes*. Keep a literary log to share what you are learning as you read this book. When you have finished the book, pick a project that reflects what you have learned.
- ☐ Learn some basic origami techniques. In addition to using books, you may want to ask the art teacher for some help.
- ☐ Create your own origami zoo. Origami figures are often animals. Choose the ones you are most interested in for your zoo. Practice making the animals until the process becomes easy. Select beautiful paper to make your final product. When you have a collection, put them together in a zoo.
- ☐ Make a collection of paper cranes. Make all different sizes and use many different kinds of paper. Put them together in a mobile.



- ☐ Plan to teach an origami class. Practice the techniques you will share with others. You need to prepare what you will say and make sure your thoughts are organized in a way that others can understand. Gather all the materials you will need. Offer to teach your origami class to your classmates.
- ☐ Make a poster showing all the different kinds of origami paper you have identified in your research. Do different colors and different sizes have different purposes? What about patterns? Make sure you plan your space carefully so that you have room for labels and a title.
- ☐ Now explore some other things to do with paper! The *Fun Things to Make and Do with Paper* book has some great ideas. Pick two or three of the projects to complete. Add these to your collection of beautiful paper creations.



PIRATES

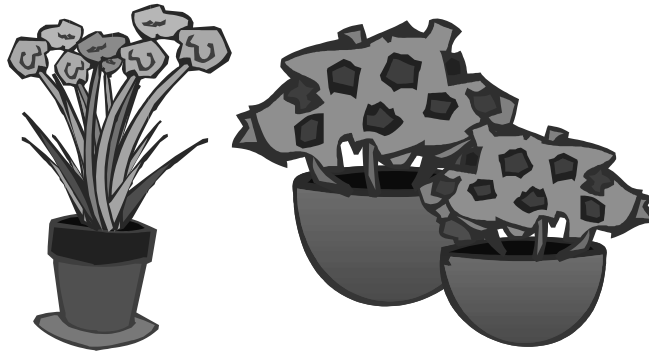


- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about pirates. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about pirates. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Thieves of the Sea: Pirates" chart.
- ☐ There are many famous pirate songs. Find several such songs and create an illustrated pirate songbook. Learn at least one of the songs and teach it to the class.
- ☐ Identify someone in your area who is an expert on pirates. Make arrangements to interview this individual. Use the "Interview Planning Sheet" to help you prepare your questions.
- ☐ As you are conducting your research about pirates, begin a "Pirate" journal. Pretend you are a pirate on a ship. Keep a journal of your adventures. Ask a teacher to help you "age" your journal when it is finished.
- ☐ Using the school and playground, create a pirate map that will lead your classmates to a treasure you hide. Use secret symbols that only pirates understand.
- ☐ Make a giant mural of a pirate ship. Include as many details as you can to make your ship look real. Include some pirates. Consider doing a skeletal view of the ship showing the internal structure.

- ☐ Design a pirate costume. Wear your costume to school and read your journal of adventures to your class. Have your picture taken next to your pirate ship.
- ☐ Create a timeline of famous pirate related events. Include maps with each incident marking the locations. Is there a pattern in the locations or the timing?



Plants

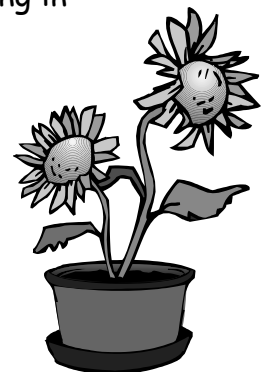


- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about plants. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about plants. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Beautiful and Practical Plants" chart.
- ☐ Create a diagram showing the different parts of a flowering plant. Along with labels for each element, include a glossary of terms on a second sheet.
- ☐ Write a flower alphabet book with information about each flower you have chosen to include in your book. Make sure to include illustrations of each specimen.
- ☐ Create two different study groups of plants. Keep a growth chart on each plant.

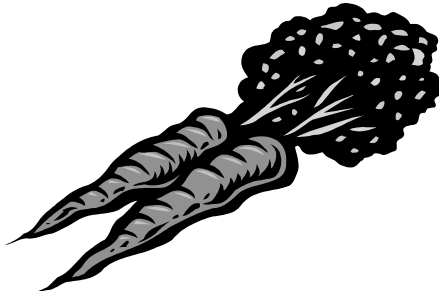
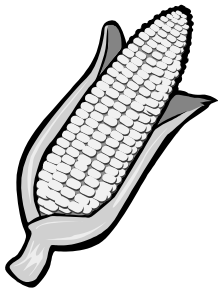
Group I-Collect three to six different soil samples from different parts of the area in which you live. Plant a small seedling in each soil sample. Each plant should have the same environment and care.

Group II -All the plants in this group will have the same soil, but different environmental conditions.

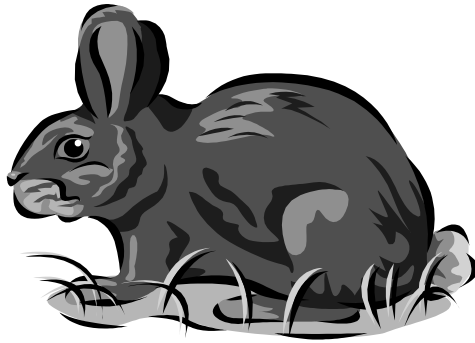
- Sample A-water, but no sun
- Sample B-sun, but no water
- Sample C-water and sun



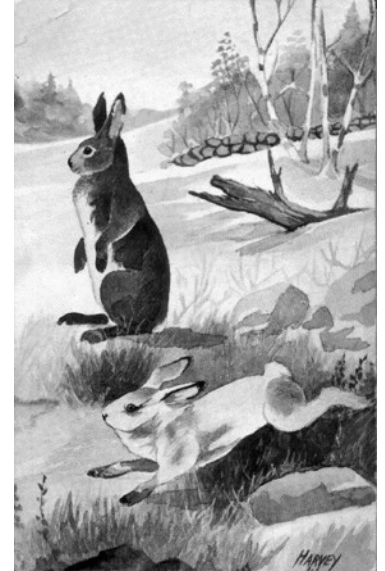
- ☐ Plan a field trip to a nature center, wilderness area, botanical garden, nursery, or nature preserve. Use a field guide to help guide you in your field experiences.
- ☐ What is photosynthesis? Write a description and use illustrations to help explain. Conduct an experiment that demonstrates an aspect of photosynthesis. Write up the results of your experiment.
- ☐ Write a book of plant poetry. Try to incorporate the facts you've learned into your poetry.
- ☐ Most people are confused about the differences between a vegetable and a fruit. Create an educational display panel for a supermarket produce department that describes the similarities and differences of the two.



RABBITS



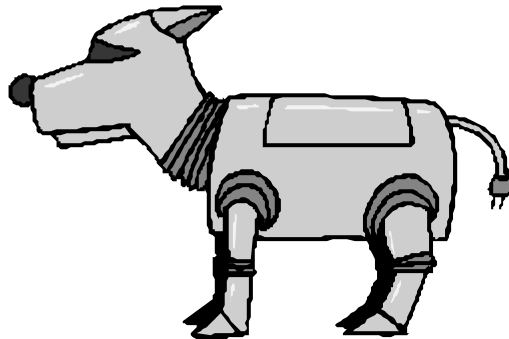
- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about rabbits. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can on rabbits. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Rabbit Reading" chart.
- ☐ Make a chart that compares three different breeds of rabbits. Some categories to consider are: size, eating habits, coloration.
- ☐ Create a diagram describing the life cycle of a rabbit. Illustrate how they look at each stage of development.
- ☐ Build a wild rabbit habitat. Make a cut-a-way model so the inside of the burrow is visible.
- ☐ Visit a meadow where rabbits live. Sit quietly and observe. Create a field guide sheet with your observations.
- ☐ Read (or have someone read to you) *Rabbit Spring* or *Rabbit Hill*. What is it like to see the world from the point of view of a rabbit?
- ☐ Many fiction books use rabbits as the main character. Write your own fiction story with a rabbit as the main character. Make a stuffed animal or puppet of the main character to go with your book.



- ☐ Plan to visit and interview someone who raises and breeds rabbits. Some things to inquire about would be:
 - What are the ideal conditions needed to raise rabbits?
 - What supplies and materials are needed?
 - How much time and money does it take to raise rabbits?
- ☐ Make a graph that shows how fast a rabbit runs compared to four other animals of your choosing.
- ☐ Make a giant rabbit shaped poster showing the skeletal structure, muscles, digestive and respiratory systems of rabbits. (You may decide to do different overlays or posters so that each system is clearly visible to the observer.)
- ☐ Find out about rabbit rescue organizations. See if there is a way that you can help support the work of one of these organizations. Perhaps you could donate time to play with the rabbits, build a hutch, help clean cages, or donate money for food and long term care.



ROBOTS



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about robots. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about robots. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Radical Robots" chart.

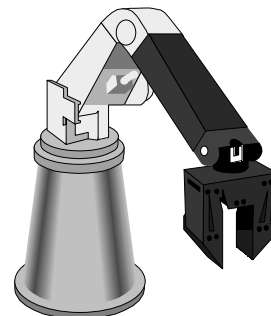
- ☐ Make a chart that will visually answer the questions:
- What kinds of jobs can robots do better and more safely than humans?
 - What kinds of jobs can humans do better than robots?

This kind of chart is usually divided into sections for each question. The question should be re-stated as a statement and displayed in the section with the information.

- ☐ Go on a "robot tour" in your community. Many businesses use robots to do work or for advertising. Robots are also available in stores for people to buy. See how many different robots you can find in your area. Keep a journal and record information about each robot. You may also want to take photographs of the robots you find.

Some places to visit:

- Police Department
- Post Office
- Sharper Image or Brookstone
- Factories
- Local hospitals



☐ Write directions for a robot to perform a simple task, like taking out the trash or making a sandwich. You will have to be very specific because a robot cannot independently problem solve. Use Chapter One of *Every Kids First Book of Robots and Computers* to help you get started. To test your instructions, ask someone to follow your instructions EXACTLY. They can't ask questions, attempt to solve any problems they encounter in your instructions, or substitute a common response. Make any necessary revisions.

☐ Read pages 24-27 of the *Usborne New Technology Book of Robotics*, and then complete the following activities:

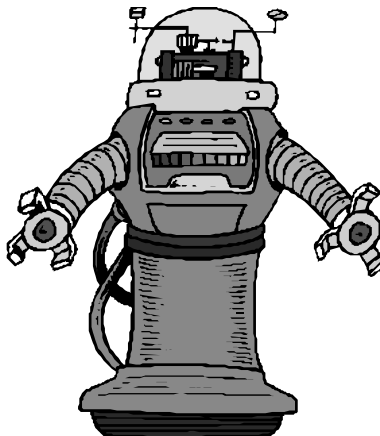
- Holding hands (pg. 26)
- How to Make your Pneumatic Gripper (pg. 25)
- Make Your Own Electromagnet (pg. 27)

☐ Select a task you would like a robot to perform. Design a robot that would be equipped for the task. Remember robots are designed for function, not looks. Create a flipbook showing your robot in action. Using recyclable materials, create a model of your robot.

☐ Make a "robot dictionary" so that others will understand what you are talking about. Some words to include are:

- | | | |
|------------------|-------------------|------------------|
| • android | • components | • computer |
| • Humanoid | • microprocessors | • monitor |
| • Optic fibers | • programmer | • prototype |
| • remote control | • robot | • self-diagnosis |
| • sensors | | |

Remember a dictionary is in alphabetical order.



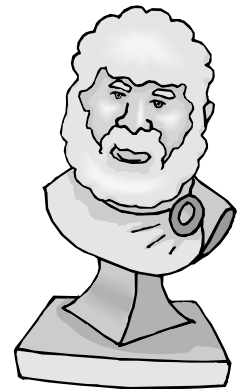


☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about sculptors and sculptures. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about sculpting. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Super Sculpting" chart.

☐ Make a poster that shows the different kinds of sculpture or the different kinds of materials sculptors use. Include pictures as examples and a written description of each.

☐ Create your own book about sculpture or sculptors. You will need to choose a way to organize your book. Some ideas are:

- Famous Sculptors
- Styles of Sculpture
- Time Periods
- Materials
- Country and Culture of Origin



☐ Pick your favorite sculptor. Find out everything you can about this person. Write a museum or gallery brochure that would help people understand an exhibit of the person's work. It would be a good idea to collect some sample brochures to look at.

☐ Interview a sculptor, using your "Interview Planning Sheet" as a guide for thinking up questions to ask. Find a way to share what you have learned.

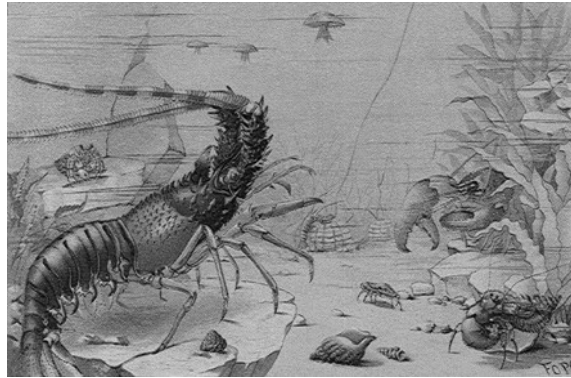
☐ Visit a local art museum or art gallery and tour the sculpture exhibits or sculpture garden to view pieces currently on display or examples of current

sculptors' work. Can you see a pattern in what the museum or gallery has decided to collect? Talk with the people who work at the gallery or museum about what they look for in sculpture and the different materials used.

- ☐ Many people are interested in environmental sculpture. Find out what environmental sculpture is and how it is produced. Create your own environmental sculpture at your school or home. Present your plan to the decision makers for approval.
- ☐ Select a material that you would like to experiment with. Create a plan for a three-dimensional piece. Work with an artists or art teacher as you begin turning your plan into a real sculpture. Describe your experience with the material when you present your piece to your class.



Sea Animals



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about various sea animals and sea life. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about sea animals and sea life. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "What You Can See at Sea" chart.
- ☐ Select one of your favorite sea animals. Examine several board and shape books published for young children. Using several of these as a model, write and illustrate a fictional shape book about a sea animal. Keep in mind some of the elements that appeal to young children such as rhyming text, interesting textures, things to manipulate, and predictable patterns of language that can be memorized.
- ☐ Make a mobile that includes at least six different sea animals. You want your mobile to make you feel as if you are lying on the floor of the ocean looking up at the creatures as they move overhead. Consider a wide range of materials (wire, felt, papier-mâché, glittery fabrics, origami) and select the one(s) that are the best match for your project.
- ☐ Visit a tropical fish store. Purchase some supplies to be used in setting up a small aquarium. Create your own care booklet for your aquarium, fish and aquatic plants so that someone else could use it to take care of the aquarium. Add a journal section and encourage other people to make notes, comments, pictures, and poems about the fish as they observe the aquarium.

- ☐ Research the food chain that exists in the ocean. Create a mural that depicts the ocean food chain. Use a variety of materials to create your mural.
- ☐ Make a flipbook of a leaping whale. Study different types of flipbooks. Study different species of whales and pictures of whales engaged in different activities and select the best whale picture to use in your flipbook.
- ☐ Create a chart of the three zones of the ocean. Explain what each zone is and the life forms that exist at each zone.
- ☐ Create your own "Whale" game. Include a game board, playing pieces and instructions. Teach your classmates the rules of the game and show them how the game is played. Consider sending a copy of your game to a whale conservation organization for them to use in their education department.
- ☐ Arrange a visit to a local aquarium or marine park. If you live in an area that does not have access to a large aquarium or marine park, try taking a virtual tour on the Internet. Many of the aquariums and marine parks around the country have interactive web sites that allow you to travel through their exhibits learning more about the sea life they support and care for.



Shakespeare

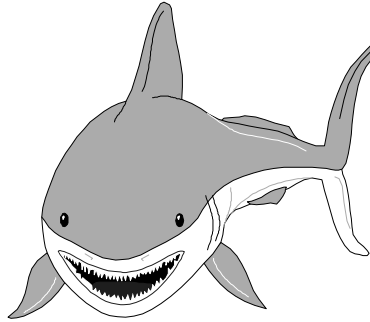


- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about Shakespeare. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about Shakespeare. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Ode to the Bard" chart.
- ☐ William Shakespeare is probably the world's most famous playwright. He was also a poet and an actor. He has contributed much to the world of literature. Where did he live? Locate his home on a map of the country of his birth. Label major cities and bodies of water.
- ☐ Shakespeare lived during the period known as the Renaissance. Explain what is meant by this term. When did the Renaissance occur? How did this historical period compliment the nature and ability of man?
- ☐ Shakespeare often wrote in blank verse, prose, and rhyming verse. Explain what these styles are and give examples.
- ☐ The Globe Theatre is well known as the home theatre of Shakespeare. Where is it? Make a scale model of it.
- ☐ The Elizabethan audience expected and got metaphors, puns, asides, conceits, similes, onomatopoeia, alliterations, assonances, synecdoches, and soliloquies. Explain and give examples of each of these terms.
- ☐ Shakespeare is credited with at least 36 plays—13 comedies, 13 historical plays, 6 tragedies and 4 tragicomedies. Explore at least one play from each category. Summarize the plot and main characters.

- ☐ Choose one of Shakespeare's plays. Design the set for this play. Either build a diorama or draw a detailed sketch. Build or draw to scale. Choose costumes designs for the characters. Remember the historical time period in your designs. You may use sketches or models for display. Specify colors and fabrics.
- ☐ Shakespeare said, "The world is a stage and every man is an actor." Explain what he meant by that statement. Do you agree or disagree. Explain your views.
- ☐ Shakespeare rarely invented his own stories or plots. Collect information about his sources. Compile a reference list.
- ☐ Critics have often noted the similarities in *A Midsummer Night's Dream* and *Romeo and Juliet*. Write a comparison essay in which you distinguish at least five points of resemblance in these two plays.
- ☐ Discover why we know relatively little about Shakespeare's life, including the actual date of his birth. Tell the class what you have learned about this man and the mystery.
- ☐ In a glossary, define 25 words from *Romeo and Juliet* or *A Midsummer Night's Dream* that are either completely new to you or are used in an unfamiliar context.
- ☐ Read *Romeo and Juliet* *Plainspoken*. Carefully compare the original play with the modern translation.

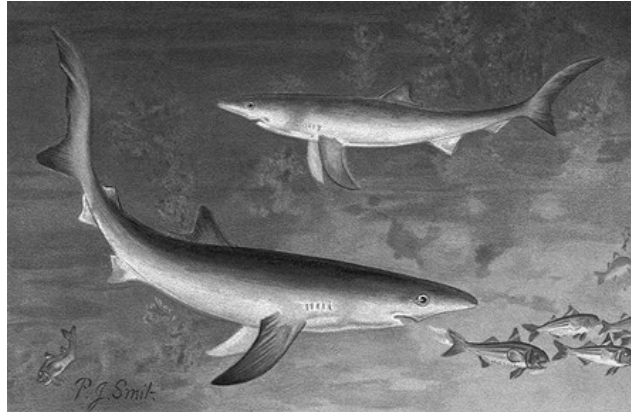


Sharks

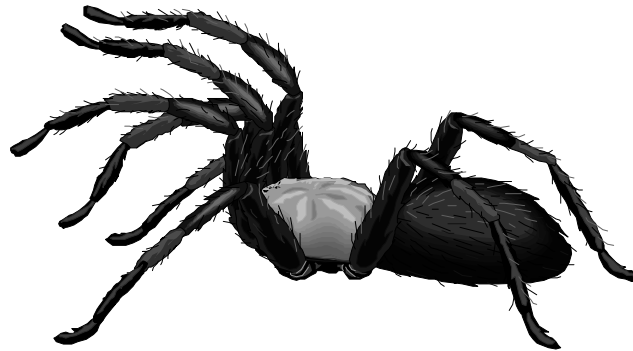


- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about sharks. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can on sharks. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Sensational Sharks" chart.
- ☐ Arrange a field trip to a pet store that specializes in tropical fish or a local aquarium. Make an appointment to interview the store manager or exhibit curator about sharks. Prepare your questions before your appointment. Examples of questions to ask might include "What is a feeding frenzy?" and "Which species of shark is the largest?"
- ☐ Compare a shark's eye and a human's eye. Create a diagram or model showing how they are alike and how they are different.
- ☐ Pretend you are a shark. Many people are frightened of sharks. Create a commercial from the shark's point of view explaining your behavior. Tell some of the good things you do.
- ☐ Using a large world map, mark the areas in which different types of sharks are found. Create a key that will help others learn more about the location of the various sharks found around the world.
- ☐ Create a display that compares the various types of sharks, detailing differences in teeth, body shape, diet, locality, and other distinguishing features. Include models, pictures, and drawings as visual aids.

- ☐ Select your favorite shark. Create a diorama showing the shark you selected in its natural habitat. Include plants and other fish and mammals that would share the habitat with your shark.
- ☐ Create a menu for a restaurant that your shark might eat at. Include all the different types of food a shark might order. Collect sample restaurant menus to get ideas for naming and describing the various dishes you will offer.



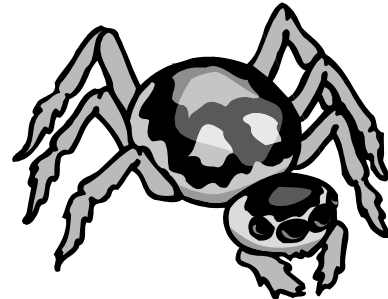
Spiders



☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about spiders. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about spiders. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Splendid Spiders" chart.

☐ Create a diagram of a spider of your choice. Label the parts. Consider creating a three-dimensional model; if you decide to create a three-dimensional model, examine some soft sculpture educational toys. Often these toys will have parts that can be removed to show something that is otherwise hidden. Be sure to include:

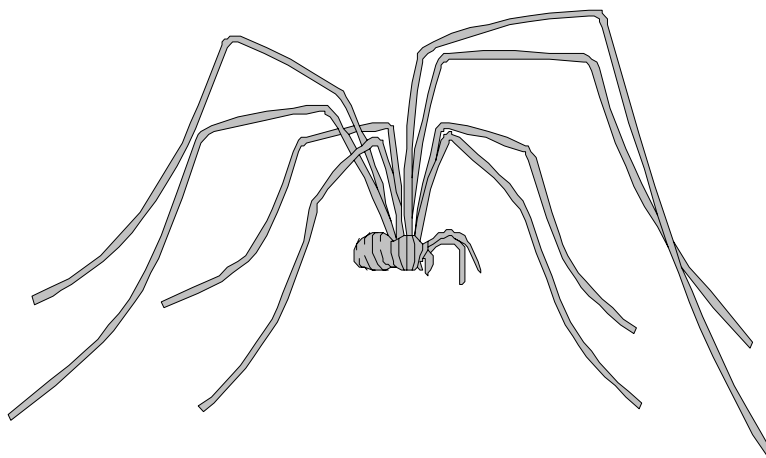
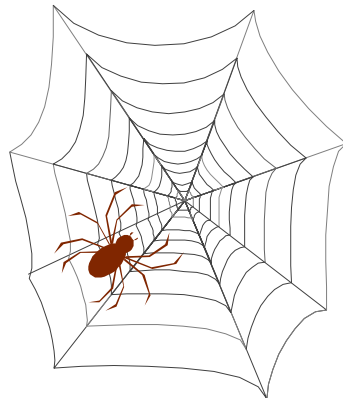
- Eyes
- Poison fangs
- Pedipalps
- Abdomen
- Air openings
- Spinnerets



☐ Write "An Amazing Spider Fact Book" based on your research. Try to identify facts that will "astound and amaze" your reader. Plan on using fancy type-faces and exclamation points to help emphasize the "incredible" nature of your findings. Include illustrations in your book.

☐ Make a mobile of different kinds of spiders. Your spiders should be detailed and accurately colored. Since many spiders are very small, plan to make each spider at least twice their actual size. Investigate different materials and select the one best suited to your project.

- ☐ Make a flip-book of a spider spinning a web, then capturing and storing the prey caught in the web.
- ☐ Read *Charlotte's Web*, either independently, with an adult, or with a friend. Create an illustrated book report to share with your class. Ask your teacher for samples of different styles of book reports and select the style you feel most comfortable with.
- ☐ Make a spider "career" chart. Explain why a spider is like an:
 - Engineer
 - Pilot
 - Telegrapher
 - Fisherman
 - HunterCan you think of any others?
- ☐ Investigate the spinnerets of a specific web-spinning spider. Create a detailed drawing that shows how the spinnerets work.
- ☐ Make your own "Web of Danger" game. You will need to make playing cards and a game board. Decide if your playing cards will be math problem cards or spider trivia cards.



Stand-Up Comedy



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about stand-up comedy. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about stand-up comedy. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Creating Comedy" chart.

Define these "humorous" terms in a creative fashion.

- burlesque • farce • hyperbole • impersonation
- irony • mimicry • parody • pun
- sarcasm • satire • slapstick • wit/witticism

- ☐ There are many types of comedy. The three most common ones emphasize character, ideas, or situations. Explain each type of comedy and give an example.

- ☐ Watch a stand-up comic. This could be an "act" or a talk show monologue. Keep a tally of how many times each type of comedy is used. Graph your results. Try to do this at least two or three times. Compare your results.

"Research focusing on humor as a profession is only a recent phenomenon, and data is very scanty; the unknown greatly outweighs the known."—Avner Ziv

- ☐ In his book, *Personality and Sense of Humor*, Avner Ziv compiles generalizations about professional and amateur humorists. Research and/or interview at least five professional humorists and interview at least five

amateur humorists. Write up your findings. Did you find the same characteristics? Do you agree with Ziv?

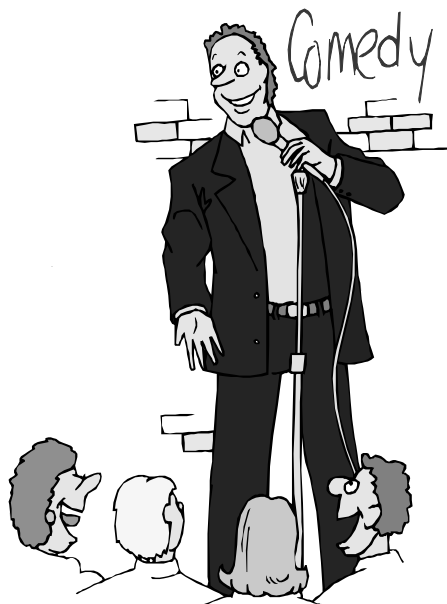
☐ Write a paper or give a speech that answers the following questions. Keep these questions in mind as you research, read, and view the topic of comedy:

- Why do people create and enjoy humor? What purposes does it serve? What are its psychological functions?
- How is humor made? What are the techniques used in creating and enjoying it?
- What is the subject matter of humor? What topics can it deal with? Are there topics that it cannot (or should not) deal with?

☐ Read *How to be a Stand Up Comic* by Belzer, Charles, and Newman, and other related books, articles, and periodicals. Keep a list of what you have read. Also keep a list of comedy acts that you watch.

☐ Select a comedian you are interested in and research that person. Select another comedian from a totally different era to research as well. Compare and contrast the two in poster form.

☐ Read *Ten Tips for Writing Humor*. Using this and other tips you have gleaned, try to write a comedy piece. Decide on the setting; will it be a monologue for a late-night television show, a television comedy show broadcast live like "Saturday Night Live," a comedy club, etc? Test out your material on the class.





☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about the theatre. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about the theatre. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Thrilling Theatre" chart.

☐ Write a children's book that will teach the reader how to become a good director. Directors have five main jobs that you should include. These are:

- Interpreting the script
- Working with designers
- Casting the roles
- Rehearsals
- Final production

☐ Pick a favorite fairy tale. Re-write the fairy tale from a different point of view in script form. Study some prepared scripts to help you get started.

☐ Pick one scene of your fairy tale script. Design three different sets of scenery for your scene. Begin by drawing the sets and then build models of the sets. Design costumes to go with your sets. Include a written explanation of why you chose the scenery and costumes.

☐ Make arrangements to visit a local theatre company or university theatre department to conduct some interviews. Plan to tour the facility. Pay close attention to the special equipment used. Use the "Interview Planning Sheet" to help you prepare.

☐ Aging someone with make-up is very difficult. Study make-up techniques and the art of make-up. Create your own make-up kit. Pick a partner and practice the "aging" techniques you have found. Take pictures of each step of the process.

☐ Make an appointment to visit a professional mime. Use your "Interview Planning Sheet" to help you prepare a list of interview questions about the art of "miming"

☐ Create your own mime act. Design your costume and practice. Use the "Practice, Perfect, Perform" guide to help you prepare. Perform your mime act for your class.

☐ Make a chart showing all the different careers in theatre. Your chart should include:

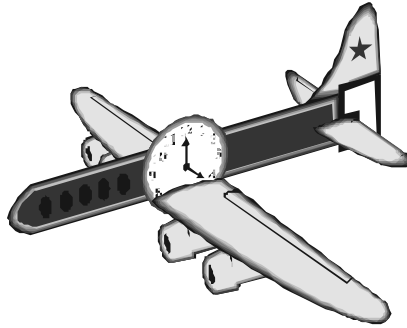
- The title of the career
- A description of the work
- An explanation of the importance of the job
- An illustration

☐ Select a poem to use for a dramatic reading. Be sure to choose one that will allow you to convey more than one emotion. Ask your teacher for some suggestions. Perform your dramatic reading for your class.

☐ Perhaps the most famous theatre in the world is the *Globe*. Create a model of the *Globe Theatre*. Create a program that might have accompanied one of the historic productions of Shakespeare's work.



Time Machines



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about time, time travel, and time machines. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about time travel. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Traveling Thru Time" chart.

Some fiction books you might consider are:

- *Tuck Everlasting*
- *The Black Cauldron*
- *Time Bandits*

Read *The Time Machine* by H.G. Wells with your parents at home.

- ☐ Read chapters 3, 4 and 7 in *This Book is About Time*. Make a timeline of the history of "keeping time". Make the different kinds of timepieces as working examples of your timeline. Work with your teacher to come up with a creative way to display your "timely" information.

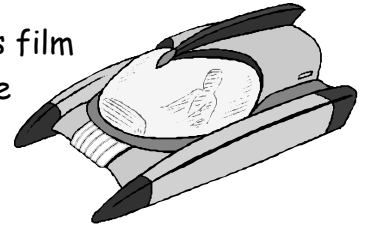
- ☐ Our year is 365.25 days long. Make a chart showing how long a year is on each of the other planets in our solar system. Organize your chart either from the longest year to the shortest year or the shortest year to the longest year. Make a second chart that shows how old you would be on each of the different planets. Combine the two charts to show both sets of information.

- ☐ Create a time capsule that will be opened by children your age 100 years from now. The time capsule should tell the children in the future about what your life is like now. You may want to create a survey to gather ideas from other students. Make a list of all the items you plan to include in your time

capsule. Think about the size the container will need to be to hold all of the items. Put your time capsule together and plan a short dedication speech. Seal your capsule and put it away.

☐ Ask your parents what they would have put in a time capsule when they were your age. Ask your grandparents the same question. Compare the things that are important to you with the things that are important to your parents and grandparents.

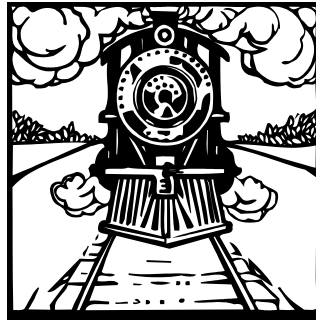
☐ Rent the movie "Back to the Future." The characters in this film traveled through time in a "jazzy" car. Create your own time machine. What elements would a machine for time travel need? Design your time machine and make a model.



☐ You are off on an imaginary journey through time. Keep a journal of your experiences. Plan to make at least three stops in the past and three stops in the future. Your journal should include as much factual information as possible, especially for the three stops in the past. Turn your journal into a play to perform for the class. You might want to use your time machine model as a prop in your play.



TRAINS and RAILROADS



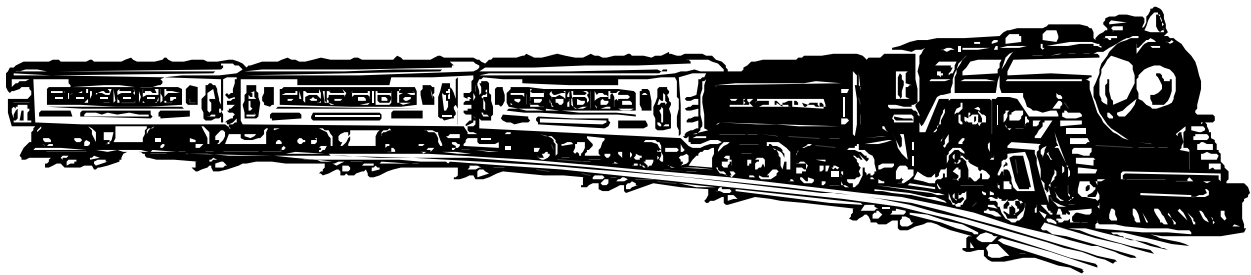
- ☐ Search your public, school, and classroom libraries and at home for any books about trains and railroads. Also search for information on the Internet. Collect all the materials you can. Research and read all you can about trains and railroads. Keep a bibliography of the books, magazines and Internet sites you researched. Record this information in your "Terrific Trains" chart.
- ☐ Find out how a steam locomotive operates. Make a poster board display of a steam locomotive and all of the working parts. Carefully label all of the components. Include a 1-2 page report describing how the steam locomotive works.
- ☐ Based on your research, determine how far a steam locomotive could travel before it had to take on more coal or water. Create a series of math word problems dealing with the steam locomotive, rate of travel, distance traveled on a set amount of fuel, etc. Include illustrations that will help someone trying to solve the problems. Publish your problems into a book for use in the classroom. If the book is laminated, you will be able to use dry erase markers to solve the problems.
- ☐ Many people are fascinated by trains. If your area has a train or railroad museum, arrange a visit and ask to speak with a museum guide or docent. Often these people will have a passion for the subject. If your area does not have a museum dedicated to the railway, try and locate a railroad enthusiast. A good place to begin looking is at local hobby shops or scale model shops.
- ☐ Read about famous train robberies. These criminals have often been "romanticized" as daring adventurers. The truth is somewhat different. Select one of the famous train robberies and write a newspaper article about the event. Be sure to include "eyewitness" accounts and commentary.

Remember the important "Who, What, When, Where, and How" of newspaper reporting.

- ☐ Research all the different types of cars a train can pull. Using recycled materials, create models of several of the more interesting cars. Create a set of museum type display cards that explain how the cars were used.



- ☐ Write a poem that will make the reader "hear" the sounds of a train as it travels through the night. You may want to consider using a standard beginning for each line, such as: "Through the dark, misty night." This type of structure, a repetitive beginning, establishes a rhythmic pattern. It also allows you to really focus on creating a visual image of the sounds of the train.
- ☐ One of the most extraordinary sections of railway track in the United States is routinely traveled by the California Zephyr as it makes its way over the Colorado Rocky Mountains. Create a model that shows the route of the railroad tracks leading from Denver to Winter Park, through Glenwood Springs and over to Grand Junction. Show the mountains, tunnels, rivers and towns that are along the way.



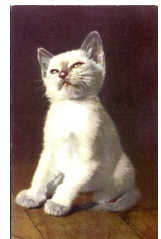
Veterinarians



☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about veterinarians. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can about veterinarians. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Visiting with a Vet" chart.

☐ Read the James Herriot children's books (you may also want to ask a parent or teacher to read aloud some sections of the adult books as well). After reading the books, write a book review for a newspaper. Be sure to read several real book reviews first so that you have a sense of the style and content.

☐ Make arrangements to visit a veterinarian's office. Use the "Interview Planning Sheet" to help you prepare a list of questions to ask during your visit. Make a detailed list of all the things you see and learn during your visit. Consider asking if you could take pictures to help you document what you see.



☐ Make a detailed diorama of a veterinarian's office. The list you compiled during your visit to veterinarian's office will be a valuable resource as you create your diorama.

☐ Write a non-fiction book for children about veterinarians. Include plenty of colorful drawings, and if possible, textures to touch or window flaps that hide surprises for the young readers to discover.

☐ Make a mobile of the different animals a veterinarian might treat. Investigate the use of different materials such as felt, paper, cloth, wire, and papier-mâché for creating elements of the mobile. Pick the material you

consider best suited to this project. Remember the objects in a mobile should be able to move in a very light breeze.

- ☐ Make a catalogue of the different kinds of equipment and medicines veterinarians use to treat animals. Look at a variety of catalogues to get some ideas about how to set up your catalog. Remember to include pictures.

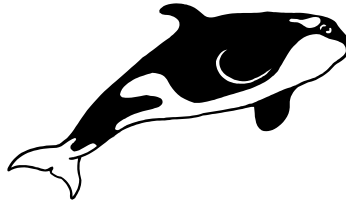


- ☐ Find out which colleges and universities offer veterinary medicine programs. Write or e-mail these institutions to request catalogues and course descriptions from each of the programs. Use a large U.S. map to locate each of the programs. What types of things does a student need in order to qualify for a veterinary medicine program?

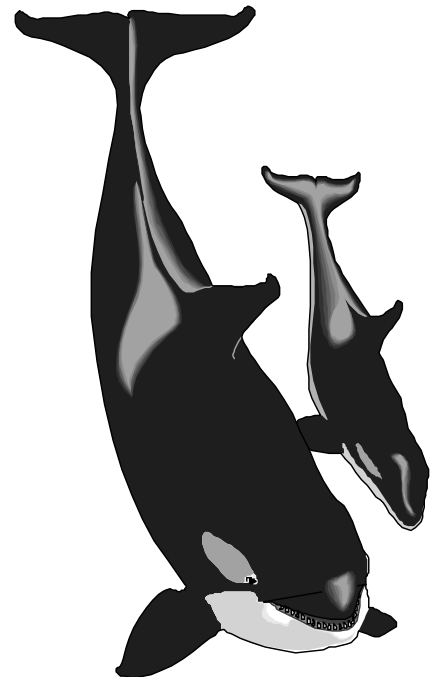
- ☐ Try to arrange a volunteer experience with a local veterinarian. Carefully prepare a presentation that will demonstrate to the vet your commitment and interest in learning more about veterinary medicine. Consider doing this after you complete your Passion Pursuit so that you could share your work in a portfolio with the vet. Offer to help in any way your vet might need. If you are able to work in the vet's office, be sure to keep a journal of your experiences.



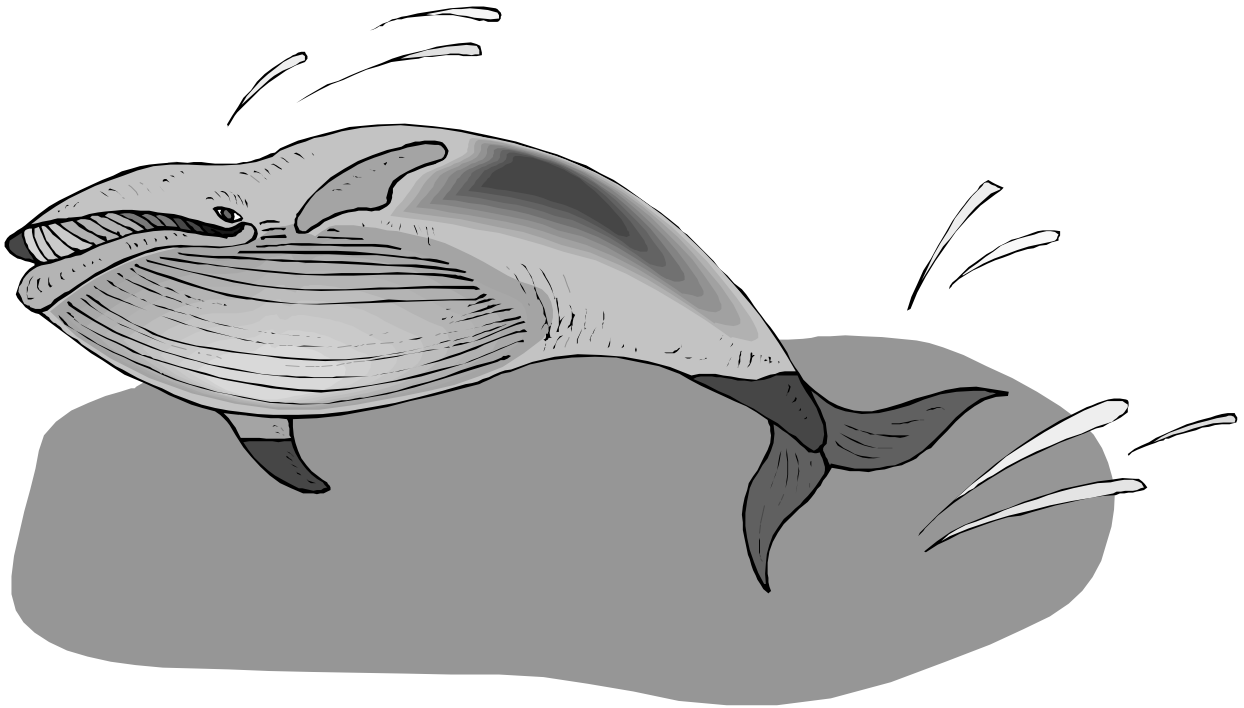
Whales



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about whales. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can on whales and their habits. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Whale Watchers" chart.
- ☐ Research the two different kinds of whales. Make a poster showing the two different whales, label the different parts of each.
- ☐ Make your own riddle book. Write riddles involving whales, their habits, and their habitats. Look for interesting facts or vocabulary words to create your riddles around.
- ☐ Make a map that shows the migration routes of whales. To increase interest in your map, make it a three-dimensional relief map.
- ☐ Write to a whale or wildlife protection agency. Ask for information about whales and whaling. Make sure to ask what you can do to help protect the whales.
- ☐ Pick your favorite whale. After researching the size of the whale, recreate the whale using chalk on a large concrete surface such as a basketball court. Lie down next to your creation and ask a teacher or friend to take a picture to document the size comparison.
- ☐ Keep a journal about the life of a whale. Imagine you are a whale and record how you spend your time. Talk about your travels, the creatures you encounter, and your family.



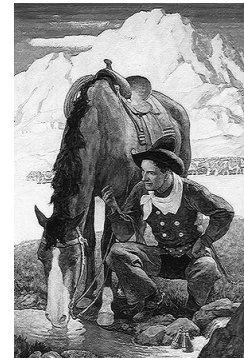
- ☐ Create a trivia game about whales. Use the information you have gathered during your research to write your questions. Design your game board and teach the rest of the class to play.
- ☐ Make a chart showing the difference between a whale and a fish. Make a list of their characteristics before you start.
- ☐ Whales live in groups. Find out what these groups are called and what they are like. Create a multimedia diorama with a typical whale grouping.



The Wild West



- ☐ Go to your public, school, and classroom libraries and check your home for any books about the frontier era of the United States. Collect all the different materials you can on this topic and bring them to school. Read and research all you can on life in the frontier. Keep a bibliography on all the books you read and record them on your "Going West" chart.
- ☐ Look at the back page of *Daily Life in a Covered Wagon* by Paul Erickson. Pick at least two places of interest and write letters asking for more information.
- ☐ The American frontier was really five different frontier areas. Research and identify the five frontiers then "map" the frontiers using a different color for each one.
- ☐ In 1851, John L.B. Soule wrote in the *Terre Haute* (Indiana) *Express*, "Go west, young man, go west." In the *New York Tribune*, Horace Greeley advised, "Go West, young man, and grow up with the country." Hundreds of people did. Why? Research why people went west and present your findings in a unique way.
- ☐ How did people get west? Research the trails used to by the settlers as they traveled west. Create a three-dimensional relief map of the United States with the major trails indicated in different colors (don't forget to include a key for your trails!).
- ☐ Play "Oregon Trail" on the computer to get a feel for the decisions and problems the pioneers faced. Write a fictional letter to relatives at home in the East describing your trip west.



☐ The type of shelter that a pioneer built was dependent upon the location and the resources present. Make a poster showing the types of homes the early settlers built.

☐ Pick at least 20 of these words/terms/names and make a PowerPoint slide show defining and illustrating each one.

Adobe	Anvil	Artifacts
Auger	Barter	Bellows
Blacksmith	Bloomers	Brave (Native American)
Breeches	Buckskin	Buffalo robe
Bullwhacker	Bustle	Calico
Chisel	Cholera	Cooper
Cut and wrought nails	Desolate	Dry goods
Dutch oven	Dysentery	Emigrant
Epidemic	Epitaphs	Erosion
Fort-niner	Frontier	Fording a river
Fur trade	Gaiters	Gingham
Gulch	Horde	Johnnycake
Keg	Knead	Knickers
Lewis and Clark	Louisiana Purchase	Manifest Destiny
Massacre	Merchandise	Merchant
Mormons	Mountain men	Pact
Pantaloons	Parasol	Pelt
Peril	Pilot bread (hard tack)	Pinafore
Post or fort	Prairie	Prairie schooner
Provisions	Rawhide	Ruts
Scurvy	Slough	Smallpox
Stagecoach	Stampede	Staple
Steep grade	Stockade fort	Swale
Switch (for beating)	Tallow	Tanner
Telegraph	Trading post	Tragedy
Transcontinental railroad	Tunic	Typhoid
Voyageur	Wagon axle	Waistcoat
Wheelwright	Whetstone	Yard goods
Yellow fever	Yeomen	Yoke

☐ Read *The Way West, Journal of a Pioneer Woman* by Amelia Stewart Knight. Make a list of some of the problems and hardships her family experienced.

☐ There are many sources of pioneer recipes. Pick a recipe and, with the help of your teacher, gather the ingredients and utensils needed to prepare your recipe for your class.

☐ Read *Tools and Gadgets* by Bobbie Kalman. Make at least one of these pioneer "tools" (or another tool of your choice!).

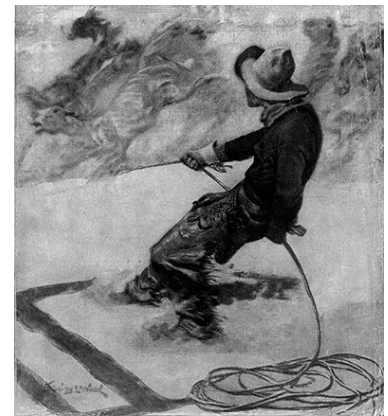
- Butter churn
- Candles
- Lantern
- Quilt

☐ Watch sections of the PBS special *Frontier House* to get a different perspective on life on the frontier. These are people from current times who were chosen to spend approximately six months of their lives living as the pioneers did. Talk with friends and adults about some of their experiences.



☐ There are many places to visit to get a feel for pioneer times. Check with a local historical society or museum. Your community may have a thresher man's festival, a quilting shop or museum, or even an antique guild that specializes in tools, furniture and clothing from the nineteenth century. Try to arrange visits to several different places to learn more about life in pioneer times.

☐ The Wild West had its share of adventurous and colorful figures: mountain men, lawmen, single pioneer women, Native Americans, soldiers and outlaws. Check out the book *Legends of the West* and pick one (you may do more) person to study carefully. Write a report about this person or write 10-15 questions you would ask this person if he/she were alive today. You might want to dress as this person and give a speech about this person to the class.



☐ Read *Children's Clothing of the 1800s* by David Schimpky and Bobbie Kalman. Draw a boy's and girl's outfit for every daywear. You might want to label any items that have unusual or unfamiliar names.

☐ Make a list of your daily schedule for a typical day. Do the same for a pioneer child. Display these schedules and write a paragraph analyzing the similarities and differences.

☐ Make a similar schedule for your mother and father. Compare their schedules with the daily routine of a pioneer man and woman. Include a paragraph analyzing the similarities and differences.

☐ Construct a diorama showing one of the following:

- A prairie schooner on the trail
- A wagon train
- A western fort
- An Indian village
- A Pony Express rider or station
- An idea of your own



☐ In 1848, gold was discovered in California. Many people rushed west to seek their fortune. A few became rich, but most lost everything they owned. Dress as a "forty-niner" and give an oral report about the real story of the gold rush.

☐ Pick one moral dilemma and write your answer in a paragraph.

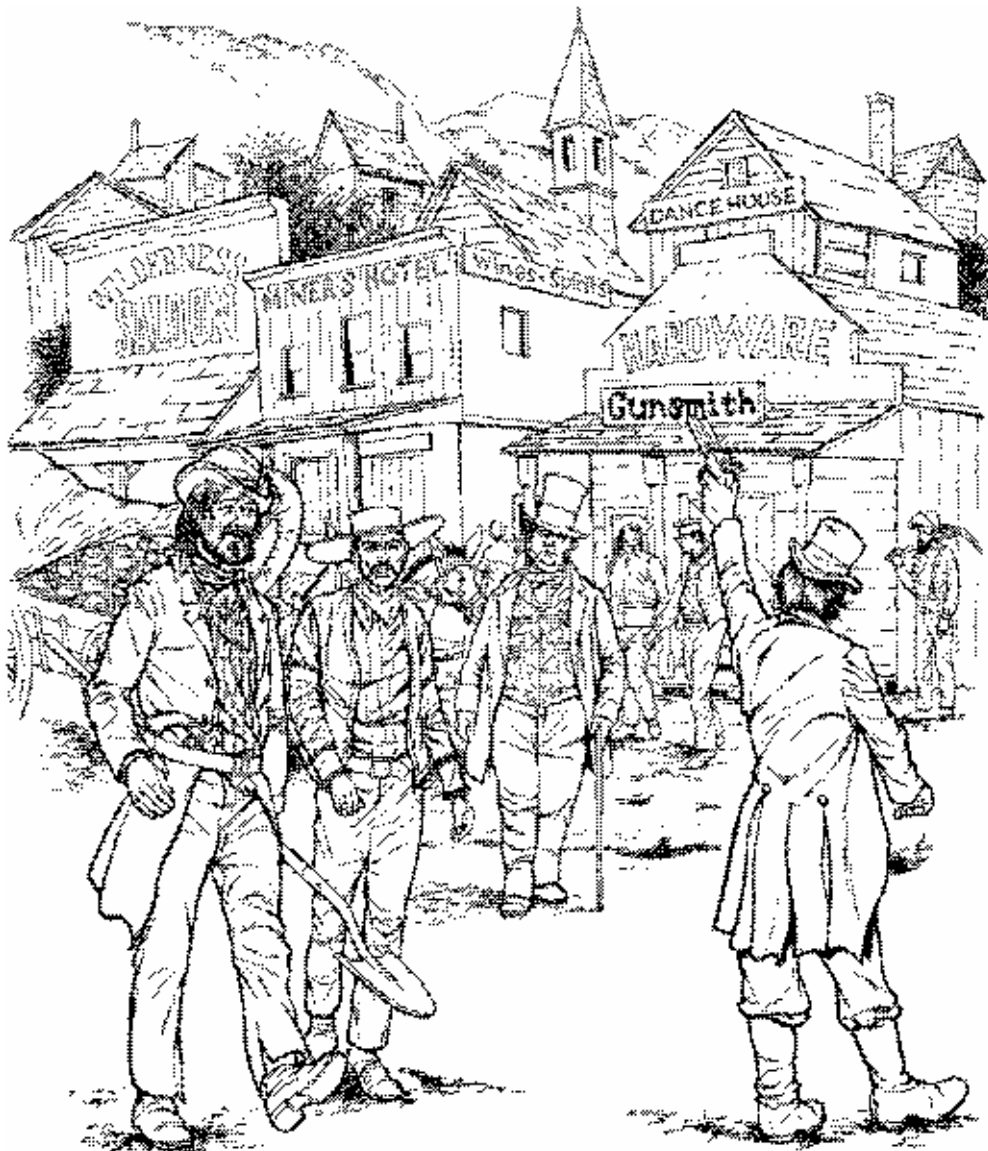
Dilemma #1—A covered wagon has broken a wheel during its trip west. The owner doesn't have an extra one. You have an extra wheel, but still have a great distance to travel. Do you give up your wheel so the other wagon can continue on its way west? Why or why not?

Dilemma #2—You and your family have been very careful to bring extra wagon parts instead of your prized possessions. One of your fellow travelers whose wagon is loaded with personal furnishings breaks a wheel. You have to decide to give up your only extra wheel or not tell that you have one. What do you do?

Dilemma #3—Your wagon is running low on meat. You have an adequate supply of other food. You spot a mother buffalo and her calf. Do you kill the mother buffalo, the calf, both or neither?

Dilemma #4—The settlers are preparing for the winter. Everyone knows that one family has not adequately put enough food and wood away for their use for the winter. During a blizzard this family comes to you for supplies. This family has not heeded the advice of their neighbors. What will you do?

☐ There were many hardships and hazards on the trail west. Create a way to show and explain the many problems the pioneers faced.



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